

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

Nine Phases • Forty-Seven Years • Nine Governments • One Documented Record

COMPLETE EDITION

Foundation through ADAP • Lougheed through Smith

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

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About This Document

FRAMING — THE STANDARD APPLIED EQUALLY TO EVERY ERA

This is not a party endorsement. This is a public record of what each government inherited, what each government changed, and what Albertans lost **and** gained as a result. Across forty-seven years, this document names actions taken by Progressive Conservative, New Democratic, and United Conservative governments. The standard is the same for each: what the documented record establishes, era by era, decision by decision.

Nine government eras. Forty-seven years. One documented record.

The chapters that follow are organized chronologically. Part One opens with a tribute to Peter Lougheed, the premier who founded the assured-income-for-the-severely-handicapped program in 1979 and who spent the last decade of his life publicly criticising the trajectory his successors set. Parts Two through Eight document each successor government in turn. Part Nine — the synthesis — draws the comparative trends across all eight eras and states the document's thesis in full.

Every claim in this document is anchored to primary sources cited inline and in the per-phase bibliographies. Government records, Hansard transcripts, contemporaneous reporting, and peer-reviewed academic research are the substrate. The campaign that published this document — The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — operates documentation-first and party-independent. The record exists. The community can use it.

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ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

This is not a party endorsement. This is a public record of what each government inherited, what each government changed, and what Albertans lost **and** gained as a result. Across forty-seven years, this document names actions taken by Progressive Conservative, New Democratic, and United Conservative governments. The standard is the same for each: what the documented record establishes, era by era, decision by decision.

Tribute to Peter Lougheed

Peter Lougheed died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that now bears his name. He was 84.

He had been Premier of Alberta from September 10, 1971 to November 1, 1985 — fourteen years. He left office decades before this document needed to be written. He did not live to see Bill 26. He did not live to see Bill 12. He did not live to see the Alberta Disability Assistance Program. He did not live to see the 88% cohabitation rule, or the Canada Disability Benefit clawback, or the May 12, 2026 fact sheet that established the framework this campaign has spent the past four months documenting.

But he did live to see the start of it. And he said, publicly and on the record, that the people who came after him were dismantling what he had built. He spent the last decade of his life telling Albertans, in interview after speech after policy paper, that the foundation was being drawn down rather than added to. He was correct. The trajectory only continued after he could no longer speak to it.

This document begins with him not because the Lougheed era was perfect — no era is — but because it is the only era in the period this piece covers when the disability community in Alberta was the subject of positive structural construction rather than negotiated subtraction. Every era after his has, on the documented record, taken more from the disability community than it has given.

He is the baseline. He is what "greatness" referenced in the title of this document means.

What He Built

Within fourteen years, the Lougheed PC government built or established the following — many of them still in operation today, several of which directly underpin the disability community's ability to exist in the province at all:

- **Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund (1976).** Established to capture non-renewable resource revenue and reinvest it for the long-term benefit of Albertans. Originally received 30% of resource royalties.
- **Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (AISH) (January 1979).** The first program in Canada designed specifically to provide assured income to people with permanent severe disabilities. Built outside the welfare system. No asset limits at founding. Pegged to senior pension rates. Built so that disabled Albertans could live with dignity and independence — Lougheed's actual framing at the time.
- **Repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (1972).** The 1928 Act, which authorized forced sterilization of Albertans deemed "mentally defective," was eliminated by the newly elected Lougheed government in one of its first major social-policy actions. Approximately 2,832 documented sterilizations had occurred under the Act between 1928 and 1972.

- **Services for the Handicapped program (1972).** First standalone division of the Department of Social Services dedicated to disability supports.
- **William Watson Lodge.** A publicly-owned wilderness lodge in Kananaskis Country, built specifically so that people with disabilities could access the Rocky Mountains alongside every other Albertan. It still operates today. Nothing comparable has been built since.
- **Royal Tyrrell Museum of Palaeontology.** Civic-cultural infrastructure on a generational scale.
- **Alexander Rutherford scholarships.** Province-wide post-secondary support for graduating Alberta students.
- **Fish Creek Provincial Park (Calgary) and Capital City Recreation Park (Edmonton).** Two large urban provincial parks built inside the province's largest cities.
- **Alberta Bill of Rights (early Lougheed legislation).** Province-level rights framework.
- **Patriation of the Canadian Constitution (1982).** Lougheed was a central negotiator in the constitutional accord that produced the Charter of Rights and Freedoms.

This is what one Alberta government built in fourteen years. The relevant question this document will return to repeatedly is what every government since has built, by comparison — and what each has drawn down from the foundation Lougheed laid.

What He Said About What Came After

Lougheed left office in 1985. He did not stop speaking. From the mid-1990s onward — and with particular intensity from 2006 forward — he gave interviews, wrote columns, and delivered speeches that constitute a sustained on-the-record critique of the Klein-era decisions that began the dismantling of his foundation. The Globe and Mail in 2008 described his late-life public engagement as Lougheed "settling accounts with Klein."

The Walrus, looking back in 2019, recorded that Lougheed had "come out of retirement" in 2006 specifically to express alarm at what he called the "rip and strip" approach to oilsands development. The Tyee, days after his death, summarised his late-life position: *"Lougheed often lamented the speed of bitumen development in the province. His motto was 'one project at a time.'"*

The words below are his, taken from interviews and speeches in his final decade. He is speaking, throughout, about resource policy — but the philosophy of stewardship that animates every quote is the same philosophy that produced AISH. Both came from the same conviction: that wealth, whether resource-based or human, belongs to the people who own it and must be managed for the long term, not extracted for the short.

"You have to look at oil and natural gas as a depleting and declining resource. And you have to manage the resource and that means to manage it with good public policy."

— Peter Lougheed, interview with Policy Options, 2012 (months before his death)

The principle generalises directly. The disability community is not a depleting resource — it is a growing one — but the same logic about *good public policy* applies. AISH was good public policy. Indexing AISH to inflation was good public policy. De-indexing it was the opposite of good public policy. Lougheed's framework names the criterion that every government since has either applied or abandoned.

"This is a sale of a depleting resource that's owned by the people. Once a barrel of oil goes down the pipeline it's gone forever. It's like a farmer selling off his topsoil."

— Peter Lougheed, quoted in Alberta Views, on resource ownership

He used the metaphor of *topsoil* deliberately. Topsoil is the precondition for everything else a farm produces. Sell it, and the farm cannot recover. The same metaphor applies to the institutional architecture of disability support in Alberta: AISH, FSCD, PDD, the appeal rights, the cohabitation rules. Each is topsoil. Each can be sold off — and much of it now has been.

"Selling the house to pay for the groceries."

— Peter Lougheed, on reckless spending of royalty revenue as current income

This phrase appears repeatedly across reporting on his late-life criticism. It is the framework he used for what Klein had done with the Heritage Fund. The same logic applies to the disability income system: the Lougheed-era assured income guarantee was the *house*, and every government since has, in some measure, sold pieces of it to fund the day.

"I don't represent with this view the majority of Albertans. But it's getting to be that more and more are agreeing with me. They're starting to be impacted by the cost factors all around us, and then they're saying, 'I remember Lougheed saying that we're going too fast.'"

— Peter Lougheed, Globe and Mail / Report on Business Magazine, August 2008

Fourteen years before the ADAP transition. Eighteen years before this document was written. Lougheed himself predicted the moment when Albertans would look back at his warnings and recognise them. This document is that moment, applied to the disability community.

Why This Tribute Opens the Document

Lougheed's principle was simple: govern as though you are the owner of what belongs to the people, not the manager of an account belonging to someone else. *Think like an owner*, as he put it. Every successor government in Alberta has thought like a manager — and manager-thinking, applied to a depleting resource and to a disability community, produces the same outcome. Both get drawn down.

Peter Lougheed died nearly fourteen years ago. The document that follows asks a question he is no longer alive to answer, but which every part of his late-life record suggests he was already answering when he could:

What has every government since done with what he built?

The answer the documented record establishes — across every party, across every premier, across forty-seven years — is the substance of this piece.

Why This Piece Exists

This is a cross-party history of Alberta disability policy from January 1979, when Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped was first established, to May 2026, when this document was first compiled. It documents what every Alberta government in that period — Progressive Conservative, NDP, United Conservative — established for the disability community, and what every Alberta government in that period took away.

The argument is not partisan. It is structural. Every party has both built and dismantled, in proportions that vary by era but never resolve in the disability community's favour over the full timeline. The trajectory across forty-seven years is downward. The trajectory at the present moment, with the AISH-to-ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026, is accelerating downward.

The thesis

Partisan-aligned advocacy has not worked. Gains made under one government have been removable, and have been removed, by the next. The 2018 indexation of AISH to inflation, achieved under the Notley NDP, was reversed within fifteen months of the Kenney UCP taking office in 2019 (Bill 20 — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act). The 1979 establishment of AISH as a dignity-based assured income program, achieved under Lougheed, has been re-engineered piece by piece under every subsequent premier — culminating in 2026 with the structural redefinition of disability income as conditional on employment activity under ADAP.

If partisan-aligned advocacy worked, the trajectory would not look like this. The trajectory looks like this *because* the disability community has spent forty-seven years depending on whichever government is in power to act in its interest. No government, of any party, has been a durable enough ally to make that strategy work.

The conclusion is the campaign's reason for existing: the disability community needs **its own representation** — community-led, party-independent, documentation-first — because no government will do this work on the community's behalf, and the historical record proves it.

How the record is built

Each era of this document is anchored to primary sources: Government of Alberta legislation and regulation, Hansard records, Open Alberta caseload data, the Disability Sector Legacy Project timeline (funded by the Alberta Historical Resources Foundation and Edmonton Heritage Council), peer-reviewed analyses, and contemporaneous news coverage. The framing is the campaign's standard discipline: *the documented record establishes*. Where motive cannot be established from documents, it is not asserted; the structural consequences are documented instead.

This is Phase One of the piece. It establishes the methodology, the comparative summary, and the Lougheed-era foundation in full. Subsequent phases will document each era to the same standard.

Part Three — Comparative Summary, 1971 – 2026

One row per Alberta government in the period. The left column names what that government established for, or directly affecting, the disability community. The right column names what was taken away, reduced, frozen, or restructured downward. Sources for every cell are documented in the era chapters that follow.

Era	Established	Took / Reduced
Peter Lougheed PC 1971 – 1985	Heritage Fund (1976) — AISH (Jan 1979) — Services for the Handicapped program (1972) — repealed Sexual Sterilization Act (1972) — William Watson Lodge — Royal Tyrrell Museum — Alexander Rutherford scholarships — Fish Creek & Capital City urban parks — Heritage Trust	Net positive era. Public criticism of his successors began in his lifetime.
Don Getty PC 1985 – 1992	Family Support for Children with Disabilities — Persons with Developmental Disabilities programs continued	Recession-era restructuring. Heritage Fund earnings transferred to general revenue (1987) — interest reinvestment ceased — slowing of social investment growth
Ralph Klein PC 1992 – 2006	AISH rate increase late period — Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act (1997) — FSCD Act (2003) — Samantha's Law (begun)	"The Klein Revolution" — public-sector cuts of 21% across departments — AISH base rate frozen for over a decade — Bill 22 (Services to Persons with Disabilities reform, 1996) — healthcare premiums introduced — Michener Centre cuts begin — 2004 "yipping cowboy-hat women" remarks
Ed Stelmach PC 2006 – 2011	AISH base-rate increase (2007 — first significant rise after Klein-era freezes) — partial restoration of social spending growth	Continued royalty drift below Lougheed-era thresholds — Heritage Fund remained capped and unindexed
Alison Redford PC 2011 – 2014	Some social-spending growth — Disability Advocate discussions begin	Mid-term mixed period; service cuts in education and social supports as fiscal pressure returned
Hancock / Prentice PC 2014 – 2015	Halt to Michener Centre full closure (Sept 2014)	Interim period — limited tenure
Rachel Notley NDP 2015 – 2019	AISH indexed to CPI — AISH base rate raised to \$1,685/month — Bill 26: An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities (2018) — first Advocate for Persons with Disabilities hired	(Within disability-policy lens, net positive era; broader fiscal critiques outside the scope of this piece.)
Jason Kenney UCP 2019 – 2022	Federal \$10/day childcare agreement signed (2021)	Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — AISH de-indexed from CPI — AISH effectively frozen — service-rule changes — early signs of structural unwinding of the Notley-era indexation

Era	Established	Took / Reduced
Danielle Smith UCP 2022 – present	AISH transition top-up (until Dec 31, 2027) — "automatic AISH retention" categories defined	Canada Disability Benefit clawback (July 2025, only province) — Bill 12 (Dec 2025) — Citizens Appeal Panel removed for ADAP — AISH inflation index capped at 2% (below CPI) — community-housing rent increase of \$220/month (Oct 2025) — ADAP transition (July 1, 2026) — 88% cohabitation rule — base-rate cut of \$200/month at transition

READING THE TABLE

The pattern is the substance of the argument. Every Alberta government in the period has both established and reduced — but the balance shifts steadily toward the right column over time, and the structural significance of what is taken grows with each era. Lougheed's right-column row is the only one without a substantive entry. By Smith's row, the right column carries the policy weight of the present moment.

The Lougheed Era, 1971 – 1985, 1971 – 1985

The foundation. The baseline against which every subsequent era is measured.

Political context

Peter Lougheed took the leadership of the Alberta Progressive Conservative Party in 1965, at the age of 36. The party held no seats. By 1967, he was Leader of the Official Opposition. In the 1971 general election, his PC government defeated the Social Credit dynasty that had governed Alberta since 1935 — ending a thirty-six-year governing tradition in a single vote. The Lougheed government was re-elected in 1975, 1979, and 1982 with increasing majorities. In 1982, on the heels of both an energy deal with Ottawa and constitutional patriation, the PCs took 75 of Alberta's 79 legislative seats.

Lougheed's governing philosophy was a deliberate departure from the Social Credit era. Where his predecessors had positioned the Alberta government as a minimal entity that stayed out of the affairs of its people, Lougheed positioned it as an active agent of modernisation, investment, and stewardship. Three Globe and Mail tributes after his death described him as the architect of "modern-day Alberta." The Canadian Encyclopedia and Policy Options have both repeatedly named him among the most consequential premiers in Canadian history.

What the Lougheed government established for the disability community

1. Repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (June 2, 1972)

One of the first major social-policy actions of the new PC government was the elimination of Alberta's 1928 Sexual Sterilization Act. The Act had authorised the forced sterilisation of Albertans deemed "mentally defective" by the Alberta Eugenics Board. Approximately 2,832 documented sterilisations had occurred under the Act between 1928 and 1972, with the vast majority performed without informed consent of the person sterilised. The Lougheed government repealed the Act on June 2, 1972. The Eugenics Board was dissolved with it.

This was the formal legal end of Alberta's institutional eugenics era. The repeal did not undo the harm done in the preceding forty-four years — that work would fall to Leilani Muir's successful 1996 lawsuit and the survivor advocacy that followed — but it closed the legislative on-ramp. No subsequent government has reopened it.

2. Services for the Handicapped program (1972)

Established as a standalone division of the Department of Social Services, dedicated to disability supports. The first formal organisational signal that the Government of Alberta treated disability as a distinct policy domain deserving of its own institutional home.

3. Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund (1976)

Established to capture revenue from Alberta's non-renewable resources and reinvest it for the long-term benefit of Albertans. Initially received approximately 30% of resource royalties. The Heritage Fund is not a disability program — but it is the underlying fiscal philosophy that made AISH possible three years later. The same vision that said *wealth from depleting resources belongs to the people and should be invested for them* also said *assured income for the severely disabled is a long-term commitment, not a budget line*. The two policies share an architecture.

The Fund peaked in real-term value in the early 1990s. Successive governments transferred its interest earnings to general revenue (Getty, 1987 onward), allowed it to stagnate (Klein), and have since drawn down its real-term purchasing power year over year. Lougheed's own subsequent criticism of these decisions — "selling the house to pay for the groceries" — is preserved in the Tribute section of this document.

4. Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (January 1979)

The founding act of Alberta disability policy as it has existed for the past forty-seven years. AISH was established under separate legislation, intentionally constructed outside the welfare system, so that recipients would not be treated as welfare recipients. It was the first program in Canada designed specifically to support adults with permanent severe disabilities.

Key founding design features:

- **Flat-rate benefit** equivalent to senior pension rates of the era. Higher than Social Assistance.
- **No asset limits.** Recipients were not penalised for owning their homes or having modest savings. This feature has been progressively eroded by subsequent governments; the current \$100,000 non-exempt asset limit is a Klein-era construction.
- **Separate legislation.** Not folded into the standard welfare statute. The legislative separation reflected the conviction that disability income was a different kind of obligation than poverty assistance — one rooted in the structural inability to earn a living rather than the temporary inability to find one.
- **Dignity framing.** The program's foundational documents and ministerial language used the words *dignity* and *independence* as core design criteria. This framing has been replaced, under ADAP, with *employment activity* and *opportunity to earn* — a structural reversal of the founding premise.
- **First in Canada.** No other province had a comparable program. The Lougheed government had no template; it built one. Subsequent provinces (and the federal Canada Disability Benefit, four decades later) drew on the AISH framework as a model.

The Lethbridge Herald, in an open letter to Premier Smith published in March 2026, framed the founding intent precisely: *"When Premier Peter Lougheed's government established the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (AISH) program in January 1979, it was so that those unable to earn enough to live, could have an assured income... AISH was specifically designed separate from the standard welfare system so that Albertans with severe permanent disabilities could live with dignity and independence. Premier Lougheed understood that we each live just one incident away from a severely disabling event."*

"One incident away." This is the same frame the ADSB campaign uses in its 2026 teach-ins under the phrase *one accident away*. The continuity between Lougheed's framing and the current campaign's framing is not coincidence. It is the rediscovery of the founding principle by a community now forced to defend it against governments that have forgotten or rejected it.

5. William Watson Lodge

A publicly-owned wilderness lodge in Kananaskis Country, built specifically to enable people with disabilities to access the Rocky Mountains. The Lodge remains in operation today. It is one of the few pieces of *physical infrastructure* in the province built specifically for the disability community. Nothing comparable in scale or intent has been constructed since.

Alberta Views, in its 2025 retrospective "The Lesson of Lougheed," described the Lodge alongside the Royal Tyrrell Museum and the Heritage Trust as among Lougheed's "institutional inheritances" — durable assets the

province continues to draw on without having added meaningfully to them.

6. The Alberta Bill of Rights and the Charter of Rights and Freedoms (1982)

Lougheed introduced provincial-level rights legislation in his first term, and was a central federal negotiator on the patriation of the Canadian Constitution and the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms in 1982. The Charter's Section 15 (Equality Rights), added in April 1985, includes *physical or mental disability* as a protected ground of discrimination. The Lougheed government's role in the patriation negotiations is structurally upstream of every disability-rights legal action subsequently brought under Section 15.

What the Lougheed government took or reduced from the disability community

Net positive era. On the documented record, the Lougheed government did not structurally reduce disability-program supports, freeze rates, restrict eligibility, or remove appeal rights during its tenure. This is the only era of the seven covered in this document where the right column of the comparative summary table is substantively empty.

This is not an unqualified endorsement. The Lougheed era pre-dates many of the disability policy domains that have since been built (the Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act, FOIP, the Personal Information Protection Act, modern accessibility legislation). The absence of subtractions from the disability community in the Lougheed era partially reflects the absence of pre-existing structures to subtract from. What can be said with confidence is that the Lougheed government did not dismantle what it built. Every subsequent government has, in varying degrees, done some of that.

Caseload context

AISH caseload data from the founding era is sparse in publicly-available records. By 2010 — twenty-five years after Lougheed left office — the AISH caseload was 41,664 (*Government of Alberta AISH Open Data*). By 2020 it had grown to 69,785, representing 1.6% of Alberta's population. By 2025 it stood at approximately 79,290 — the figure currently being processed through the AISH-to-ADAP transition.

The growth in caseload is partly demographic (population growth and aging) and partly diagnostic (broader recognition of qualifying conditions, particularly mental health and neurological conditions, that would not have been documented as AISH-qualifying in 1979). It is structurally significant that no Alberta government since Lougheed has built a disability program of comparable scope to absorb the caseload growth its predecessor anticipated. The growth has been absorbed by stretching the original program, not by constructing a second one.

The Lougheed conclusion

Peter Lougheed built the foundation of Alberta disability policy during a period of exceptional fiscal capacity and exceptional political consensus. He did so against the explicit alternative of treating disability as a welfare problem; he built a structure that treated it as a permanent civic obligation. He repealed the legislative on-ramp to Alberta's eugenics era and replaced it with an assured income program that the rest of Canada eventually imitated. He created physical infrastructure for the disability community in the form of William Watson Lodge. He framed the program in language — *dignity, independence, one incident away* — that the community has

held onto and is now defending against a government that no longer uses those words.

Every era of this document that follows is, in one way or another, the story of what was done with what Peter Lougheed built. The story is not flattering. He himself, in his last decade, said so. The full record now confirms what he tried to warn about while he was still alive.

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PART TWO

The Getty Era

1985 – 1992

The Getty Era, 1985 – 1992

Don Getty inherited Lougheed's Alberta. He did not get to keep it.

Of all the eras documented in this piece, the Getty era is the one most freighted with tragedy. Donald Ross Getty was Peter Lougheed's chosen successor, his friend, and the former Edmonton Eskimos quarterback who had served as Lougheed's Energy Minister and Intergovernmental Affairs Minister. He was one of the "Original Six" Progressive Conservative MLAs elected with Lougheed in 1967. He was — per the Government of Alberta's own biographical record — part of "a small core group that conceived the Heritage Savings Trust Fund" in 1976. He helped build the architecture this entire document is, in one way or another, the story of.

He also halted it. In 1987, during his sixth year as Premier, Getty's government stopped the transfer of 30% of provincial energy revenues to the Heritage Savings Trust Fund — the mechanism Lougheed had constructed to ensure that Alberta's non-renewable resource wealth would compound rather than be spent. The Fund has effectively flat-lined in real terms ever since. The decision was made under conditions of genuine fiscal crisis. It was also the structural beginning of the give-and-take pattern this document traces across the forty-seven years that followed.

The Getty era is not the era of dismantling. That distinction belongs to his successor. But the Getty era is the era in which the dismantling first became thinkable — when the Lougheed-era principle of reinvestment was, for the first time, overridden by the logic of current operating necessity. Every era that follows draws structurally on the precedent the Getty era established.

Political context

Donald Ross Getty was born August 30, 1933 in Westmount, Quebec. He graduated from the University of Western Ontario in 1955 and joined the Edmonton Eskimos as a quarterback the same year. He was named the Western CFL's "Outstanding Canadian" in 1959. He left professional football for the energy business, joining Imperial Oil in 1955 and rising through several oil and gas enterprises through the 1960s. In 1967 he was among the "Original Six" PC MLAs elected with Peter Lougheed, taking the Edmonton riding of Strathcona West. He served under Lougheed as Minister of Intergovernmental Affairs and Minister of Energy through the founding decade of the modern PC dynasty.

Getty left politics in 1979 for the private sector, taking board positions at Interprovincial Pipe and Steel Corporation, Genstar Corporation, Nova Corporation, and the Royal Bank of Canada. When Lougheed announced his retirement in 1985, Getty returned to win the PC leadership on the second ballot of a bitter contest. He was sworn in as Alberta's 11th Premier on November 1, 1985, at age 52.

The honeymoon ended almost immediately. In early 1986, the global oil market collapsed. OPEC, having spent two years defending high prices through production cuts, reversed course and flooded the market. Within months, the price of oil fell from approximately US\$27 per barrel in late 1985 to approximately US\$10 per barrel by mid-1986 — a decline of approximately 60% in a single fiscal year, with brief periods near US\$7. Alberta, whose entire fiscal model rested on royalty revenue from a commodity that had just lost three-fifths of its value, was structurally exposed.

The fiscal numbers tell the story of the era. The Government of Alberta posted a record \$3.3 billion deficit in 1986 — the first deficit of the modern PC era. Five more deficits followed in succession. By the time Getty left office in December 1992, accumulated provincial debt had reached approximately \$20 billion. The Heritage Fund's assets, at that moment, totalled roughly \$12 billion. **The province's debt exceeded the value of its own savings fund.**

Getty's response combined three measures: tax increases, spending cuts across health, education, and social services, and — critically — the suspension of the 30% Heritage Fund transfer mechanism. The PC majority was reduced from 75 of 79 seats (Lougheed's 1982 high-water mark) to 61 of 83 seats in the May 1986 election, and reduced further in 1989. He did not seek a third term. Ralph Klein won the PC leadership in December 1992 on an explicit platform of more cuts, faster.

What the Getty government established for the disability community

The Getty government's positive contributions to disability-related policy were modest in scale but real. They occurred under fiscal conditions that made any new spending difficult, and they reflect the continued operation of the Lougheed-era institutional framework that Getty had inherited and could not fully fund.

1. The Brassard Review — "Claiming My Future" (1989)

Roy Brassard, MLA for Olds-Didsbury (elected in 1986) and then-Associate Minister of Family and Social Services, led a legislative review committee whose 1989 report — *Claiming My Future: A Person with a Mental Disability — Today and Tomorrow* — was the first major Alberta legislative review of developmental disability policy since the deinstitutionalisation movement began in the 1970s. The report is preserved in the academic record as a primary source (Sonpal-Valias, "History of Developmental Disability Policy in Alberta," School of Public Policy Publications, University of Calgary, 2019).

The Brassard Review's significance is historical rather than legislative — its recommendations did not produce immediate statutory change. But it represents the Getty government's continued public engagement with developmental disability policy during a period when no positive engagement was fiscally guaranteed. The review's framing — *claiming my future* — anticipates by three decades the community-led, person-first language now central to disability rights discourse.

2. Ministry of Seniors (1991)

In 1991, Premier Getty established a new, dedicated Ministry of Seniors — separating seniors' affairs from the broader Family and Social Services portfolio for the first time. Roy Brassard was named the inaugural Minister. The creation of a dedicated ministry was a structural acknowledgement that seniors' issues — many of which overlap with disability supports (cognitive decline, physical impairment, AISH transitions at age 65, long-term care) — deserved their own institutional home. The ministry has operated, under varying names and configurations, ever since.

3. Continued operation of AISH and the Lougheed-era disability framework

Within the documented record available to this campaign, the Getty government did not structurally reduce AISH benefits, freeze the program's base rate (those decisions are Klein-era), or remove appeal rights. AISH continued to operate on the architecture Lougheed had established. The Services for the Handicapped program continued. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities precursor programs continued.

This is consistent with the era's broader fiscal pattern: Getty reduced spending in discretionary lines (health, education, general social services) while preserving rights-based statutory programs whose costs flow from population eligibility rather than annual appropriation. Whether that pattern reflects principled protection of disability income or simply administrative inertia in a crisis-driven budget cycle is a question the documented record does not answer.

4. Family Day (1990) — broader civic context

Outside the disability-policy lens but worth noting for completeness: Getty created the statutory holiday of Family Day in 1990. It is a small civic legacy, and the Government of Alberta's own biographical materials emphasise it as a defining Getty-era achievement.

What the Getty government took or reduced

The Getty era's structural significance for this document — and for every era that follows — is concentrated in a single 1987 decision. Several additional reductions in health, education, and social services accompanied it. None of them, on the surface, directly targeted the disability community. All of them, in aggregate, established the fiscal and political precedent for everything that came afterward.

1. The 1987 Heritage Fund decision

From its founding in 1976 through fiscal 1986–87, the Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund had received an automatic transfer of 30% of provincial non-renewable resource revenues. The transfer was the structural mechanism by which the Fund grew. Lougheed had designed it specifically so that the Heritage Fund's growth would not be subject to the annual political fight over operating dollars; the transfer was law, not discretionary appropriation.

In 1987 — six years after his death, Lougheed's structural protection was overridden. The Getty government's response to the 1986 oil collapse and resulting deficits included a decision to suspend the 30% transfer. The mechanism was not formally abolished; it was suspended through subsequent budget actions, then never restored. The Globe and Mail, summarising the Fund's history in 2015, recorded the moment precisely:

"The Heritage Fund grew steadily through its first decade with an annual investment of 30 per cent of provincial energy revenues. In 1987 Premier Don Getty put a stop to the transfers and subsequent governments have spent largely all of Alberta's energy revenues. Despite strong investment returns and some small top-ups, the fund's value has essentially flat-lined."

— The Globe and Mail, "What happened to Alberta's cash stash," April 2015

The structural meaning of this decision cannot be overstated. The Heritage Fund peaked in real-term value at approximately \$24 billion in the early 1980s. By 2014 — twenty-seven years after Getty halted the transfers — the Fund had a market value of approximately \$15 billion in inflation-adjusted terms. Norway, whose oil-development model Lougheed had been the inspiration for, used the same period to grow its sovereign wealth fund to approximately US \$1 trillion by the end of 2017 (the year the Government Pension Fund Global passed the trillion-dollar threshold for the first time) and approximately US \$2 trillion by late 2025 (Norges Bank Investment Management; Government Pension Fund of Norway). The difference between \$15 billion and \$1 trillion in 2017 — let alone \$2 trillion today — is the cost, in real, generational, owed-to-Albertans dollars, of the 1987 decision and its successor decisions.

Lougheed spent the last decade of his life publicly criticising this trajectory. As documented in Phase One, he framed the drawdown as *"selling the house to pay for the groceries."* He did not name his successor by name. He did not need to. The math is unambiguous: the drawdown began in 1987, under Lougheed's chosen successor and personal friend, in response to an oil price collapse that the Heritage Fund had been specifically designed to insulate Alberta against.

THE STRUCTURAL POINT

The Heritage Fund is not an AISH program. But the philosophy that built the Heritage Fund — that wealth from a non-renewable source must be reinvested rather than spent on current operations — is the same philosophy that built AISH as an assured income outside the welfare system. When the Heritage Fund's reinvestment mechanism was suspended in 1987, the philosophy that protected AISH from being treated as a discretionary budget line was weakened in proportion. Every government that followed has drawn from both. The trajectories run in parallel.

2. Cuts to health, education, and social services (1986–1992)

Alongside the Heritage Fund decision, the Getty government imposed spending reductions across health, education, and social services, paired with tax increases, in successive budgets through 1986–1992. The specific quanta of each cut are documented in Alberta Treasury budget records of the era and have been summarised in Getty's obituary coverage:

As Global News summarised in its February 2016 obituary coverage: Getty led the province for seven years, with many highs and lows. He created Family Day in 1990, and was a strong advocate for senate reform. But finance was a constant issue during his tenure. The collapse in oil prices — from approximately US\$27 per barrel in late 1985 to approximately US\$10 by mid-1986 — forced Getty to put the brakes on spending. He raised taxes and imposed cuts in health, education, and social services; at the same time, he directed government resources toward supporting business.

The disability-policy significance of these cuts is indirect rather than direct. AISH itself was not targeted. But the broader social-services envelope from which AISH-adjacent supports flow — Family and Social Services operating budgets, the institutions that would later become PDD service providers, the Family Support for Children with Disabilities precursor framework — absorbed significant reductions during the Getty years. This is the documented record. The same record establishes that the institutional infrastructure around AISH was thinner when Getty left office than when he took it up — and the structural vulnerability he created became the basis for the more direct Klein-era reductions that followed.

3. The drawdown trajectory begins

The most consequential aspect of the Getty era for this piece is not any single decision but the establishment of a *pattern*: that under fiscal pressure, the Government of Alberta would draw down from Lougheed-era institutional savings rather than raise revenue to maintain them. The Heritage Fund halt was the first instance. The cuts to health, education, and social services were the second. The acceptance — by both government and the public — that this was the legitimate response to a revenue shock established the rhetorical and political conditions for the much larger reductions that began in 1992.

Lougheed's later critique of the drawdown is reproduced in Phase One of this piece. He spoke about resource policy explicitly. He did not, in any documented interview the campaign has located, name disability supports as a specific concern. But the principle he kept restating — that depleting wealth must be reinvested, not spent as current income — applies with equal force to social infrastructure. AISH was depleting wealth. Every subsequent reduction in AISH's real-term value has been the policy equivalent of *selling off the topsoil*.

Caseload context

AISH caseload data for the Getty era is sparse in publicly-available records, and the Open Alberta data series begins meaningfully in the 2000s. What can be established from departmental annual reports of the period (Alberta Family and Social Services, *Annual Report 1989–1990*; *Annual Report 1994–1995*) is that AISH continued to grow modestly through the late 1980s and into the early 1990s as the program matured and diagnostic categories broadened. The growth was not dramatic. The structural significance of the era is on the fiscal side, not the caseload side.

The Getty conclusion

Don Getty was a man of genuine personal integrity, by every account preserved in the documented record. His son Darin said at the time of his death: *"A son could not have had a better father."* Patrick Delaney, his former executive secretary, said: *"I don't think anybody saw the pending crisis with oil prices."* The University of Alberta awarded him an honorary Doctor of Laws degree in 2013 for his stewardship through the recession. Even Danielle Smith, the leader of the Alberta opposition at the time of his 2016 death, called him a man of great personal integrity.

This piece does not require those judgments to be wrong. It requires only that the documented record establish what was done — by whatever government, for whatever reason, with whatever moral character — and what the structural consequences for the disability community have been. The structural consequence of the Getty era is the 1987 Heritage Fund decision. It is the moment when the Lougheed-era principle of reinvestment was, for the first time, overridden by the logic of current necessity. Every era that follows draws on that precedent.

Getty himself appears not to have framed the 1987 decision as a break with Lougheed. The documented record suggests he understood it as a temporary suspension in response to a crisis he had not chosen and could not control. The temporariness, on his original framing, was the operating assumption. It was the governments that followed — Klein, Stelmach, Redford, the entire PC dynasty through 2015, and the UCP era thereafter — that made the suspension permanent. Getty halted the transfer. They never restored it.

Phase Three of this piece, when written, will document the era in which the drawdown stopped being a fiscal response and became a political project. **Ralph Klein took office in December 1992 on the explicit promise of doing more of what Getty had done — faster, deeper, and as policy rather than as crisis management.** The disability community, having survived the Getty era without direct programmatic reductions, would not survive the Klein era the same way.

Bibliography — Phase Two sources

Sources specific to or directly underpinning the Getty-era chapter. To be merged with the Phase One bibliography seed and subsequent phase bibliographies when the full document is assembled.

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PART THREE

The Klein Era

1992 – 2006

The Klein Era, 1992 – 2006

Ralph Klein did not inherit Don Getty's drawdown. He chose it. Then he accelerated it.

Where the Getty era was the period in which the Lougheed-era reinvestment principle was first suspended under conditions of fiscal crisis, the Klein era is the period in which the same suspension was reframed as a political project — pursued not because revenues had collapsed, but because a particular ideological account of government had become the governing philosophy of Alberta. The dismantling Lougheed criticized in his retirement is the dismantling that began in earnest under Klein.

Over his first three years in office (1993–1996), Klein's government cut Alberta program spending by over 21% — the steepest sustained reduction in any Canadian province in the post-war period. Welfare rolls were cut roughly in half during that period. Twenty thousand public sector jobs were eliminated. Tuition rose sharply. Healthcare cuts of 20% in the 1994 budget produced waiting lists that have never since been resolved.

Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped rates were frozen. Services for people with disabilities, in the broader sense, were cut back. Homelessness climbed 740% over Klein's fourteen years in office.

And in October 2004, eleven days before what would be his fourth and final election win, Klein stood at a Calgary campaign rally and described two AISH recipients who had approached him at a sod-turning. He said: *"They didn't look severely handicapped to me. I'll tell you that for sure. Both had cigarettes dangling from their mouths, and cowboy hats."* The crowd of three hundred party faithful laughed. He doubled down the next day with the phrase *severely normal*, applied to the Albertans who *didn't* need to talk about AISH because they were not disabled. He won the election. The disability community absorbed the cost.

Political context

Ralph Phillip Klein was born November 1, 1942 in Calgary. He was a television reporter at CFCN-TV through the 1970s, and was elected Mayor of Calgary in 1980 — a position he held until 1989, building a populist reputation through bluntness, accessibility, and occasional public outbursts. In 1982 he attracted national attention by publicly denouncing Eastern Canadians moving to Calgary as *"bums"* and *"creeps"*, and calling on city police to *"kick ass"* to get them out of town.

Klein entered provincial politics in 1989, winning the riding of Calgary-Elbow on his first attempt. He served in Don Getty's cabinet as Minister of the Environment. In December 1992, with Getty stepping aside in the aftermath of the cumulative deficits documented in Phase Two of this piece, Klein won the PC leadership race on a platform explicitly framed as a break from the Getty era — faster cuts, deeper cuts, balanced budgets within years, not decades.

His founding political mantra became, and would remain throughout his tenure, a single sentence: *"We don't have a revenue problem. We have a spending problem."* Every subsequent Alberta premier of any party who has invoked fiscal discipline as a reason for social-services cuts has been quoting, directly or indirectly, that 1993 framing. It was the most consequential single sentence in Alberta political history of the period this document covers.

Klein won the June 1993 general election on the strength of that framing. His Conservatives took 51 of 83 seats. He won subsequent majorities in 1997, 2001, and 2004 — the latter being the campaign in which the AISH controversy erupted. He resigned the PC leadership in late 2006 amid internal party pressure and a non-confidence vote of his own caucus's mandatory review. He died on March 29, 2013, of complications from frontal lobe dementia, at age 70.

His self-described "revolution" — the term was used in government communications of the era — was framed at the time, and is framed by his admirers today, as a fiscal rescue. Independent analysis has been less generous. The Parkland Institute's retrospective work documents that Alberta's accumulated debt in 1992, when Klein took office, stood at approximately \$8 billion — and that combined provincial subsidies to oil-and-gas and agriculture between 1986 and 1992 totalled \$11.2 billion. **The subsidies had exceeded the debt.** The Parkland conclusion: Klein cut social spending to pay for subsidies the government had chosen, in a province with the lowest taxation rates in the country, during a structural revenue shortfall that revenue-side measures could have addressed. The cuts were a choice, not a necessity.

A note on debt figures across this document. Phase Two of this piece cites Alberta's accumulated provincial debt at the end of the Getty era as approximately \$20 billion. The Parkland figure of approximately \$8 billion above refers to a different measurement: accumulated deficit net of Heritage Fund assets at the moment Klein took office. The \$20 billion figure is gross provincial debt; the \$8 billion figure is net accumulated deficit. Both are defensible under their respective definitions. The structural argument in both phases — that Klein inherited fiscal pressure significantly smaller than the subsidy bill the same government chose to maintain — holds under either accounting.

What the Klein government established

The Klein era is not exclusively a record of dismantling. Several pieces of legislation and program architecture relevant to the disability community were established during his tenure. Their significance is mixed — in most cases, they created governance structures rather than spending commitments, and in several cases the governance structures themselves became the mechanism for downstream service reductions.

1. Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act (June 18, 1997)

Statutory framework establishing the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program with regional community boards. The Act's preamble contains some of the most expansive language ever used in Alberta legislation about people with developmental disabilities:

"WHEREAS the people of Alberta honour and respect the dignity and equal worth of adults with developmental disabilities; WHEREAS it is important that adults with developmental disabilities have opportunities to exercise self-determination and to be fully included in community life; WHEREAS the individual needs of adults with developmental disabilities are most effectively met through the provision of services that are based on equitable opportunity, funding and access to resources..."

— Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act, preamble (1997)

The preamble's language directly echoes the Lougheed-era framing of disability supports as a dignity and rights matter rather than a welfare matter. The contradiction — that the same government enacting this language was simultaneously freezing AISH rates and cutting program spending across health and social services by over 21% — is one of the central paradoxes of the Klein era. The Act articulated principles the government's fiscal practice did not honour.

The PDD program established under this Act today serves approximately 12,000 adults with developmental disabilities and operates with a budget approaching \$1 billion (Sonpal-Valias, 2019). Its existence as a distinct statutory program is part of the Klein-era legacy — but every Alberta government since has had to address shortfalls between the Act's stated principles and the PDD program's actual capacity.

2. Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act (2003)

Established the legislative framework for the Family Support for Children with Disabilities (FSCD) program. Provides funding and support to families raising children with disabilities — covering services such as respite, specialized aides, behavioural supports, and therapies. The Act was the first statutory framework in Alberta dedicated specifically to families of children with disabilities. It remains in force today.

The 2009 amendment establishing **Samantha's Law** (named after Samantha Martin, a young Albertan with severe disabilities who died in foster care) extended FSCD coverage and tightened oversight requirements. The amendment was a Stelmach-era act (Phase Four of this piece) but built on the FSCD framework Klein's government had enacted.

3. Late-era AISH rate adjustment (post-2004)

Following the public backlash to Klein's October 2004 remarks (documented later in this chapter), and the broader fiscal recovery that had occurred under the Klein years, his government implemented a partial AISH rate adjustment in the final years of his tenure. The base rate, which had stood at \$850/month at the time of

the 2004 controversy, was raised — though the increase did not approach what a fully-indexed AISH rate would have been if the Lougheed-era senior-rate parity had been maintained throughout the freeze.

The post-2004 adjustment is documented in Government of Alberta records and is consistent with the pattern Klein himself acknowledged in his clarifying statement: *"I know that virtually all AISH clients are people who, through no fault of their own, require assistance so that they can live their lives with dignity and comfort."* The adjustment did not restore the structural ground lost during the freeze. It also did not reach the level needed to keep pace with inflation since 1993. AISH recipients in 2006 had less real purchasing power than AISH recipients in 1993, on any reasonable inflation-adjusted measure.

Independent assessment of the Klein-era AISH trajectory by AU Press (2021), in *Working People in Alberta*, places the freeze and subsequent partial adjustment in context:

"Services for people with disabilities were cut back, and Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (AISH) rates were frozen. Seniors were particularly hard hit, with the amalgamation of five programs into a single, new, income-tested Alberta Seniors Benefit, which proved deleterious to middle-income seniors and of only marginal benefit to the poorest retired Albertans."

— AU Press, *Working People in Alberta*, Ch. 8: "Revolution, Retrenchment, and the New Normal: The 1990s and Beyond"

What the Klein government took or reduced

The bulk of the Klein-era record sits in this column. The reductions were not isolated events but a structurally-linked program of public-sector contraction, executed within the first three years of his tenure and consolidated through the next eleven.

1. The 1993–94 budget — the revolution begins

Klein's first full-cycle budget, tabled in early 1994, set the structural template for everything that followed. The headline cuts:

- **20% cut** to health care
- **21% cut** to post-secondary education funding grants (with tuition rising significantly to absorb the gap)
- **12.4% cut** to K-12 education
- Cuts to disability services and supports across the social-services envelope
- Average **16% cut** across priority areas; **30% cut** across many other departments
- Twenty thousand public-sector jobs eliminated between 1993 and 1994
- Rollbacks in wages and benefits for the public-sector workers who remained

Within two years of the 1993 budget, total Alberta program spending had declined by over 21%. By 1995 the operating deficit was eliminated. By 1996, debt interest payments began to fall. The Klein government's communications celebrated this trajectory as the "Alberta Advantage" and used it as the rhetorical foundation for further tax cuts in subsequent years. The Globe and Mail's 2019 retrospective captured the era plainly:

"There were 30-per-cent cuts to many government departments, and even priority areas such as education, health care, postsecondary education and social services had their budgets slashed by an average of 16 per cent. [...] It was a difficult few years: Tens of thousands of public servants lost their jobs and thousands of people were forced off welfare. Protests erupted outside hospitals."

— The Globe and Mail, "Alberta budget reminiscent of Ralph Klein's 'miracle on the Prairie'," October 2019

2. AISH rate frozen; disability services cut back

The AU Press analysis above documents the AISH freeze and the broader reduction in services for people with disabilities as part of the 1993–94 cuts. The freeze was not announced as a deliberate AISH-specific policy — it was implemented through the omission of a rate adjustment in successive budgets, leaving the base rate stuck at a 1993-era figure while inflation eroded its real value year over year.

By the time of Klein's October 2004 election controversy, AISH recipients received \$850/month — a figure that, in 2004 dollars, represented a meaningful real-term decline from the program's founding parity with senior pension rates in 1979. Approximately 31,500 Alberta residents received AISH at that time. About half received the maximum stipend; the remainder received reduced amounts based on partial qualifying income.

3. Welfare rolls cut in half

Klein's government's most aggressive single social-policy intervention was the restructuring of Alberta's welfare system in 1993–94. Within one year, welfare rolls were cut in half — not by addressing underlying poverty, but by tightening eligibility rules, introducing workfare requirements (assessment of capacity to work, with social assistance denied or clawed back based on that capacity), and reducing benefit levels.

The Canadian Labour Congress retrospective records that during the Klein years, **homelessness in Alberta climbed 740%**. The two trends are causally linked: people removed from welfare did not stop existing. They became homeless, became dependent on family, became cost transfers to municipalities, charities, and the criminal-justice system. The provincial budget shrank. The downstream costs absorbed by other systems did not.

4. Five seniors' benefits consolidated into one less generous one

Alberta had operated five distinct senior-benefit programs prior to 1993. Klein's government consolidated them into a single income-tested Alberta Seniors Benefit. The structural effect was a benefit reduction for middle-income seniors and, per the AU Press analysis above, *"only marginal benefit to the poorest retired Albertans."* The consolidation also created a precedent — programmatic simplification framed as efficiency — that would be invoked again in the 2026 ADAP transition documented in the ADSB campaign's existing work.

5. Healthcare premiums and public-sector privatization

Klein's government introduced and maintained Alberta Health Care Insurance premiums (monthly user fees on residents for access to the public health system) as a revenue instrument throughout his tenure. The premiums were not eliminated until 2008, under his successor. Multiple privatization initiatives were pursued during the Klein years, including the contracting-out of laundry services in Calgary hospitals in 1995 — the decision that produced the Calgary laundry workers' strike of November 1995 (documented by the Alberta Labour History Institute), which was one of the few moments in the Klein years when sustained public pressure forced the government to reverse a specific cut.

6. The October 2004 election remarks

The single most-documented moment of the Klein era in relation to the disability community occurred on the evening of Wednesday, October 27, 2004, at a Progressive Conservative campaign rally in Calgary, with approximately 300 party faithful in attendance. The provincial general election was scheduled for November 22, 2004 — twenty-six days away. The 2004 election was already expected to be Klein's fourth straight majority.

Klein, in the course of his speech, described an encounter he said he had recently had with two women at a sod-turning event. The women, he said, had approached him to complain about AISH payments. The Globe and Mail's reporting from the next day preserved his exact words:

"And they were yipping about AISH payments. They didn't look severely handicapped to me. I'll tell you that for sure. Both had cigarettes dangling from their mouths, and cowboy hats."

— Ralph Klein, Calgary PC campaign rally, October 27, 2004

The crowd laughed. Klein continued: *"We will look at potential and absolute abuse of the system and cut those people off."* When asked by reporters after the speech whether he was concerned about offending anyone, he replied: *"I'll offend people abusing the system and I don't mind that."*

The next day, October 28, at a campaign stop in Grande Prairie, a reporter attempted to get him to clarify the remarks. He did not respond to the question directly. He then addressed the matter from the podium:

"I know the CBC wants me to talk about AISH. I'm sure none of you want to talk to me about AISH, do you? No, because you're normal. Severely normal."

— Ralph Klein, Grande Prairie campaign stop, October 28, 2004

Severely normal — applied to the Albertans who did not need AISH because they were not, in his framing, disabled. The premier of the province publicly delineating the rhetorical line between his electorate (*severely normal*) and the AISH recipient population, twenty-five days before an election he was certain to win.

Alberta Liberal Leader Kevin Taft called the comments mean-spirited and said they played to the stereotype of welfare abuse. NDP Leader Brian Mason said Klein was *"bullying the disabled."* Klein's campaign issued a written clarification later the same day:

"I know that virtually all AISH clients are people who, through no fault of their own, require assistance so that they can live their lives with dignity and comfort. I also am very aware that for many, disabilities are not always outwardly visible. In my earlier comments, I in no way intended to suggest that there is rampant abuse of the AISH program."

— Office of Premier Ralph Klein, written statement, October 28, 2004

The clarification did not retract the original remarks. It contextualised them. The phrase *severely normal* was never withdrawn. Klein won the November 22 election with another PC majority — 62 of 83 seats. The disability community absorbed the political cost of having been the rhetorical foil in the closing weeks of a

successful campaign.

WHY THIS INCIDENT MATTERS FOR THE FULL DOCUMENT

The Klein 2004 remarks are not included here as a moment of personal embarrassment, or as a one-off gaffe. They are included because they document — in the premier's own words, at his own campaign event, with his own political clarification on file — the specific rhetorical move that the entire give-and-take pattern of this document depends on: the framing of disability income recipients as suspect, as potentially undeserving, as a category requiring policing rather than support. Every subsequent reduction in AISH-adjacent programs — under any government, of any party — has invoked some version of this framing, even where the language has been softened or proceduralised. Klein said it plainly. He did so because he believed Albertans would tolerate hearing it plainly. The documented record establishes that, in 2004, he was correct.

Caseload context

Alberta's AISH caseload grew throughout the Klein years despite the rate freeze, reflecting both demographic growth and broader recognition of qualifying conditions. By October 2004 the caseload stood at approximately 31,500 recipients (Globe and Mail, October 2004). By the time Stelmach took office in late 2006, the caseload was approximately 36,000 (CBC News, 2008). The base rate at end-of-Klein-era stood at \$1,000/month for a single adult — meaningfully higher than the \$850 of 2004 but, in real-term inflation-adjusted dollars, still below the program's 1993 starting point.

Welfare caseloads tell the inverse story. Alberta's welfare rolls in 1993 stood at approximately 94,000 cases. By 1996 — three years after the Klein restructuring — they had been reduced to approximately 50,000. The reduction is the source of the "welfare rolls cut roughly in half" framing in the Canadian Labour Congress and Alberta Labour History Institute retrospectives. The downstream homelessness increase of 740% is partially the displaced population from these welfare reductions, partially the displaced population from the AISH freeze's compound effect on disabled Albertans who could not work and could not earn enough to keep pace with rising rents.

Lougheed's response to the Klein era

Peter Lougheed left office in 1985 — seven years before Klein won the PC leadership and twenty-one years before Klein left office. Lougheed died in 2012, six years after Klein stepped down. The intervening period — roughly 1995 through 2012 — was the most publicly active stretch of Lougheed's post-political life, and almost every documented statement of substance he made in that period was, in one way or another, a critique of the trajectory Klein had set.

The Globe and Mail's 2008 profile of Lougheed framed the matter explicitly:

"Public-spirited Lougheed may be, but he is also settling accounts with Klein, the roughneck radio reporter-turned-politician who ruled Alberta from 1992 to 2006. Peter McCormick, a political scientist at the University of Lethbridge, thinks of Klein as the interloper who stole the Conservative party from the party establishment; the establishment was, above all, Peter Lougheed, and the establishment regarded Klein as a hoodlum."

— The Globe and Mail / Report on Business Magazine, August 2008

In 2006 — the final months of Klein's premiership — Lougheed came out of public retirement to deliver speeches and grant interviews opposing what he called the *"rip and strip"* approach to oilsands development. The Walrus retrospective captured the moment: *"This 'rip and strip' approach got so overcharged that, in 2006, Peter Lougheed came out of retirement to express alarm."* Lougheed's primary critique was directed at resource policy. His secondary critique — implied in every metaphor he reached for — was directed at the broader Klein-era pattern of treating long-term provincial assets as current operating revenue.

The Lougheed quotes documented in Phase One of this piece — *"selling the house to pay for the groceries," "think like an owner," "this is a sale of a depleting resource that's owned by the people"* — all date from this period. They were not abstract philosophical observations. They were targeted critiques of specific Klein-era decisions, delivered by the man whose foundational vision Klein was dismantling. Lougheed did not name Klein in most of these interviews. He did not need to. Every Albertan who heard him knew exactly which premier he was talking about.

The disability-policy significance of Lougheed's critique is indirect — he did not, in documented interviews this campaign has located, name AISH or PDD or FSCD specifically. But the structural principle he kept restating — that wealth and institutions built for the long term must be reinvested rather than drawn down for current operations — applies with equal force to social infrastructure. The Klein-era AISH freeze, the welfare restructuring, the seniors benefit consolidation, the disability services cuts — each was a drawdown of social infrastructure that the Lougheed era had built. Lougheed criticised the principle. The principle's application to the disability community is the subject of this document.

The Klein conclusion

Ralph Klein governed Alberta for fourteen years — longer than every premier in the period this document covers except Lougheed. He won four consecutive majorities. He was, by every measure of electoral success, the most successful premier of his generation. He balanced the budget. He paid down the debt. He produced what his finance minister called "the Alberta Advantage."

He also presided over the most significant single-era reduction in disability-community supports in modern Alberta history. The AISH freeze cost recipients real purchasing power they have never recovered. The welfare restructuring displaced tens of thousands of Albertans into homelessness and downstream dependency. The seniors benefit consolidation reduced supports for the poorest retired Albertans. The 2004 election remarks established the rhetorical template by which AISH recipients could be publicly characterised as suspect by the premier of the province, and the political price for doing so was negligible. The PDD Community Governance Act of 1997 contained beautiful preamble language about dignity and equal worth. The fiscal practice of the same government contradicted the preamble in every line of the operating budget.

Klein was not the worst premier of the period for the disability community in absolute terms — that distinction will be examined in Phases Seven and Eight. He was the premier who established the structural framework that made everything after him possible. The policy template he wrote in 1993–94 — that disability supports are discretionary spending, subject to fiscal-restraint logic, justified by appeals to abuse and undeservedness — has been the operating template of every subsequent UCP government and, in less aggressive form, has been the assumption that even sympathetic NDP governments have had to argue against rather than override.

Lougheed spent the last seventeen years of his life saying so. He was correct.

Phase Four of this piece documents the Stelmach era — the period in which a successor PC government, with significantly more fiscal room than Klein had ever had, undertook a partial restoration of AISH and disability supports. It is the only PC-era restoration documented in this piece. Its limits, and what it could not undo, are the substance of the next chapter.

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PART FOUR

The Stelmach Era

2006 – 2011

The Stelmach Era, 2006 – 2011

Ed Stelmach is the only Progressive Conservative premier in this document who attempted to undo any part of what Ralph Klein had taken. He partially succeeded. Even his partial success did not reach what Lougheed had originally built.

Of all the eras documented in this piece, the Stelmach era occupies the most awkward structural position. It is a partial restoration era within a long-term dismantling trajectory — neither the continuation of Klein's revolution nor a full reversal of it, but a five-year window in which a less ideological PC government, with significantly more fiscal room than Klein had ever enjoyed, attempted to repair some of what the preceding fourteen years had damaged. The repair was real. It was also insufficient.

Stelmach raised AISH rates for the first time in any meaningful way since 1993. He eliminated the Klein-era healthcare premiums that had functioned as a regressive user fee on the public system for over a decade. His government signed Samantha's Law into effect — a citizen-led amendment to the Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act that was driven by a grieving mother's persistence, not by government initiative, but which the Stelmach government had the political will to pass. The 2009 Protection for Persons in Care Act expanded oversight of vulnerable Albertans in institutional settings. The Stelmach government's record on disability policy is, by the standards of the period this document covers, the most genuinely positive of any PC government after Lougheed.

And it still wasn't enough. The most-cited independent analysis of the 2007 AISH rate adjustment, by University of Calgary economist Ron Kneebone, established that the rate had less purchasing power than the program's 1993 rate. The restoration restored less than what had been lost. The structural template Klein had established — that disability income was discretionary spending, subject to annual political judgment — was not dismantled. It was merely operated more humanely for five years. As soon as the political winds shifted, the same template would be re-activated, and the gains of the Stelmach era would prove reversible. They were.

Political context

Edward Michael Stelmach was born May 11, 1951 in Lamont, Alberta, into a Ukrainian-Canadian farming family. He attended the University of Alberta, did not complete his degree, and returned to the family farm at Andrew, Alberta. He served as a county councillor and reeve of Lamont County before winning the provincial riding of Vegreville-Viking (later Fort Saskatchewan-Vegreville) in 1993. He served under Klein as Minister of Agriculture, Food, and Rural Development (1997–1999); Minister of Infrastructure (1999–2001); Minister of Transportation (2001–2004); and Minister of Intergovernmental Relations (2004–2006).

When Klein stepped aside in late 2006, Stelmach won the PC leadership race in a second-ballot upset, defeating frontrunners Jim Dinning and Ted Morton. The first ballot was held November 25, 2006 (Stelmach placed third, behind Dinning and Morton); on the December 2, 2006 second ballot, Morton's preferential second-choice support broke decisively toward Stelmach, who took 53.9% to Dinning's 38.5%. He was sworn in as Alberta's 13th Premier on December 14, 2006. He inherited a province at the height of the pre-2008 oil boom — fiscal conditions Klein himself had never operated under.

In the March 3, 2008 general election, Stelmach's Tories won 72 of 83 seats — the largest PC majority since the Lougheed era. The result was widely interpreted as a vote of confidence in the PC dynasty more than in Stelmach personally, but it gave him an unambiguous mandate. The 2008 global financial crisis hit the Alberta budget within months. Stelmach's government returned to deficit through 2009 and 2010. He resigned the PC leadership on January 25, 2011, citing internal caucus tensions and the political fallout from his 2007 Royalty Review. Alison Redford succeeded him in October 2011.

Stelmach died on May 25, 2023, at age 72. His Government of Alberta biographical record preserves his self-framing: a farmer and small-town councillor whose governing style was consensus-driven, fiscally cautious by Alberta standards, and consciously distanced from the more aggressive elements of the Klein-era PC playbook.

What the Stelmach government established

This is the only era in the document where the "established" column carries more substantive weight than the "reduced" column. Each of the actions below is structurally documented and was achieved within Stelmach's five years in office.

1. AISH rate increase — May 2007

In May 2007 — five months after Stelmach took office — his government raised the maximum AISH benefit from \$1,000 per month to \$1,088 per month, the first meaningful base-rate increase since the Klein-era freezes began in 1993. The increase came in the immediate aftermath of Klein's October 2004 election remarks (documented in Phase Three of this piece) and the public criticism that followed. It was, by any reasonable reading, a deliberate distancing from Klein's rhetorical posture toward AISH recipients.

Subsequent Stelmach-era adjustments raised the rate further. By 2008 the rate stood at approximately \$1,050 (some inconsistency between published figures; CBC reporting from February 2008 cites \$1,088 as the May 2007 figure; Alberta Views' Kneebone analysis references \$1,050 in 2007). By the end of Stelmach's tenure in 2011, the maximum AISH rate had reached approximately \$1,188 per month.

The independent academic assessment of this restoration, by University of Calgary economist Ron Kneebone, is the most important single finding of this chapter:

"According to Ron Kneebone, economics professor at the University of Calgary, the 2007 benefit of \$1,050 a month was actually lower in purchasing power than \$850 was in 1993. "If we wanted to keep the payout at the same value that it was in 1993," he says, "it would have to be \$1,172.""

— Alberta Views, "Overhauling AISH"

WHAT THE KNEEBONE ANALYSIS ESTABLISHES

The Stelmach-era AISH increase was real. It was also insufficient to restore the program to its 1993 purchasing power, much less to its 1979 founding parity with senior pension rates. To match 1993 real-term value at the time of the 2007 increase, the rate would have needed to be approximately \$1,172 — meaningfully higher than the \$1,088 actually delivered. By the end of Stelmach's tenure in 2011, the rate had approached this 1993-equivalent figure for the first time in eighteen years — but only barely, and the gains would be erased again within fifteen months of the Kenney UCP government taking office in 2019 (Phase Seven).

2. 2008 employment exemption proposal — partially implemented

Going into the March 2008 election, Stelmach announced a proposal to raise AISH employment-income exemptions significantly — single adults would be allowed to earn \$1,500 per month (up from \$400), and single parents or couples \$2,500 (up from \$975), without losing AISH benefits. The proposal was structured as a campaign promise. Per CBC reporting at the time, it would have affected approximately 6,100 of the then-36,000 AISH recipients who were working.

Stelmach's reasoning, in his own framing at the announcement at the Alex Community Health Centre in Calgary: *"We often hear that they want to work because it boosts their self-esteem when they're in the workforce."* The framing was paternalistic by 2026 standards but, in 2008, represented one of the first

government-level acknowledgements that AISH recipients who could work some hours should not be punished for doing so by near-100% clawbacks. The exemption was partially implemented in subsequent budgets but did not reach the campaign-promise levels.

Independent commentary on the announcement, captured in the same CBC report, recorded the limits of the proposal — Bev Matthiessen of the Alberta Committee of Citizens with Disabilities said the rate exemption was "a good first step" but should be substantially higher; Pat Brown, a Calgary AISH recipient struggling with addictions and mental health and previously homeless for three years, said: *"It's very difficult to survive on AISH. That's why I was homeless for so long."* The Kneebone analysis above explains why.

3. Healthcare premium elimination (2009)

Alberta Health Care Insurance premiums — monthly user fees paid by Alberta residents to the public health system, introduced and maintained through the Klein years — were eliminated by the Stelmach government in 2009. The premiums had functioned as a regressive user fee, falling proportionally hardest on lower-income Albertans, AISH recipients, and seniors on fixed incomes. Their elimination was supported across party lines at the time and has been repeatedly cited by subsequent commentators as one of the Stelmach era's most significant policy decisions.

The premiums have not been reintroduced, despite multiple subsequent attempts (Jim Prentice's 2015 attempt was abandoned mid-campaign; subsequent PC and UCP governments have considered and rejected the idea on political grounds). The 2009 elimination is, in this narrow respect, a permanent Stelmach-era contribution to the post-Klein rebalancing.

4. Samantha's Law — Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act amendment (December 3, 2009)

Samantha Lauren Martin was born on June 4, 1993, in Alberta, with tetrasomy 18p — a rare chromosomal condition causing significant medical and developmental complexity. Alberta social workers advised her family that Samantha would receive better medical support if she were placed in foster care, where provincial funding could be accessed for her care. Her mother, Velvet Martin, has stated that the placement was effectively coerced — the only mechanism by which the funding could be accessed required guardianship relinquishment.

Samantha lived in foster care for more than ten years. She returned to her biological family five months before her death. On December 3, 2006, she died of cardiac arrest at Stollery Children's Hospital in Edmonton, age 13. Her mother subsequently fought — and won — a court action to lift the publication ban that, under Alberta law at the time, prevented her from naming her own daughter publicly. The court action allowed Velvet Martin to begin advocacy for legislative change.

On December 3, 2009 — the third anniversary of Samantha's death, and the same date the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities was tabled in the federal House of Commons — the Stelmach government passed an amendment to the Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act. The amendment, known as Samantha's Law, established that **families could no longer be required to surrender guardianship of their disabled children in order to access government funding for medical and developmental services**. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities Program was formally separated from child intervention services.

Velvet Martin's recognition came years later. She received an International Human Rights Award in 2015, presented at Edmonton City Hall, for her advocacy. The Samantha's Law framework continues to operate. The

principle it established — that disability supports should not be conditional on family separation — is one of the durable Stelmach-era contributions to Alberta disability law.

WHO ACTUALLY DROVE THIS LEGISLATIVE CHANGE

Samantha's Law was not a government initiative. It was the product of seven years of advocacy by Velvet Martin, who fought the publication ban, the foster-care system that had held her daughter for a decade, and the legal framework that had required the relinquishment of guardianship as a condition of accessing disability supports. The Stelmach government's role was to pass the amendment Velvet Martin had spent those years constructing the political conditions for. This is what citizen-driven legislative reform looks like. It is also, by direct extension, what the ADSB campaign is doing now — constructing the political conditions for legislative change that no government will initiate on its own.

5. Protection for Persons in Care Act (February 2009)

Enacted in February 2009 (per the Disability Sector Legacy Project timeline), the Protection for Persons in Care Act expanded mandatory reporting obligations and oversight for vulnerable Albertans in institutional care settings, including persons with developmental disabilities, seniors in long-term care, and recipients of various government-funded support services. The Act has been amended several times since its passage. Its original framework remains in force.

What the Stelmach government took or reduced

The Stelmach era is, on balance, a net positive era within the scope of this document. But "net positive" is not "unambiguously positive," and the reductions and walked-back reforms documented below are part of why the partial restoration was partial.

1. The 2007 Royalty Review — walked back under industry pressure

In late 2007, Stelmach's government conducted a Royalty Review chaired by accountant Bill Hunter. The Review's report — *Our Fair Share* — recommended an increase in oil-and-gas royalty rates that would have moved Alberta closer to the Lougheed-era 30% royalty target. Stelmach initially accepted the recommendations and announced a rate increase. The oil-and-gas industry response was swift and coordinated: drilling activity was reduced, capital was reallocated to other jurisdictions, and a sustained public-relations campaign attacked the Review's findings.

By 2009 — under pressure from industry, falling oil prices in the aftermath of the 2008 financial crisis, and his own caucus — Stelmach's government rolled back substantial elements of the Royalty Review's recommendations. The structural shift toward the Lougheed-era royalty regime did not survive. Alberta returned to one of the lowest royalty regimes among major oil-producing jurisdictions, a position it has maintained in every subsequent fiscal cycle to the present moment.

The disability-policy significance of the Royalty Review walk-back is indirect but structural. The royalty revenue forgone in 2009 was, in net-present-value terms, substantial — and it was forgone in a province that has, in every subsequent fiscal cycle, cited revenue shortfalls as justification for social-services restraint. The Royalty Review was Stelmach's most ambitious attempt to restore the Lougheed-era fiscal framework. Its failure is, in retrospect, one of the structural causes of why subsequent Alberta governments have continued to treat disability programs as discretionary spending.

2. Post-2008 fiscal contraction

The 2008 global financial crisis hit Alberta's oil-revenue-dependent budget hard. Stelmach's government returned to deficit through 2009 and 2010. Spending growth across ministries was constrained, and several planned expansions of disability-adjacent programs were deferred or scaled back. The AISH rate increases continued but at diminished pace. The 2008 election promise of \$1,500 single-adult employment exemptions was not fully delivered. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities program absorbed budget pressure, with families reporting tightened eligibility criteria and longer wait times for services — patterns that have continued under every subsequent government to the present moment.

3. AISH did not return to 1979 parity

Even at the high point of the Stelmach-era AISH increases, the program's base rate did not return to its 1979 founding parity with senior pension rates. The 1979 design premise — that disability income should match the income paid to seniors on the basis of the same demonstrated structural inability to earn a working income — had been broken during the Klein years and was not restored under Stelmach. The structural separation of AISH from senior-pension-equivalent value has been a continuous feature of every Alberta government from Klein to the present. Stelmach narrowed the gap. He did not close it.

Caseload context

AISH caseload grew steadily through the Stelmach years, continuing the trend that began in the late 1990s. Approximately 36,000 Albertans received AISH at the start of Stelmach's tenure in 2006. By the time he left office in 2011, the caseload had grown to approximately 41,664 (per the Open Alberta 2010 data point cited in the Wikipedia framework). The growth represents both demographic expansion and broader recognition of qualifying conditions, including mental health diagnoses that would not have been consistently recognised as AISH-qualifying in 1979.

Welfare caseloads tell a different story. Per Maytree's longitudinal Income Support analysis, *"The proportion of Income Support beneficiaries decreased gradually until 2007-08, followed by a period of fluctuation between 1.5 per cent and 2.5 per cent from 2008-09 to 2013-14."* The 2008 financial crisis stabilised what had been a decade of Klein-era welfare reduction, but did not reverse it. Welfare in Alberta has, since 1996, operated at structurally lower caseload levels than it did pre-Klein — a Klein-era achievement Stelmach's government did not undo and subsequent governments have not revisited.

The Stelmach conclusion

Ed Stelmach governed Alberta for five years. He won the largest PC majority since Lougheed. He inherited a fiscal environment that gave him room to act, lost most of that room to the 2008 financial crisis, and still managed — within five years — to deliver the only meaningful AISH rate restoration of the post-Lougheed period; the elimination of healthcare premiums; the passage of Samantha's Law; and the Protection for Persons in Care Act.

He also walked back the Royalty Review. He did not return AISH to 1979 parity. He did not undo the Klein-era welfare restructuring. He did not establish indexation of disability supports to inflation. The structural template Klein had constructed — that disability income was a discretionary annual budget decision — was operated more humanely under Stelmach. It was not dismantled. And because it was not dismantled, every gain of the Stelmach era was reversible by any successor who chose to reverse it.

Within fifteen months of the Kenney UCP government taking office in 2019, the AISH indexation that had been established under Rachel Notley in 2018 (Phase Six) was reversed by Bill 26. The structural template Klein had built — and that Stelmach had not dismantled — was reactivated. The Stelmach-era gains were not protected by their passage. They were protected only by the continued political will of subsequent governments to maintain them. That will did not last.

Stelmach's record stands as proof that PC governments could — under conditions of fiscal capacity and political will — make meaningful improvements to disability supports in Alberta. His record also stands as proof that those improvements could not survive the absence of either condition. The lesson the ADSB campaign draws from the Stelmach era is the lesson Lougheed kept stating throughout his retirement: structural protection has to be built into the institutional architecture itself, not left to the discretion of the premier-in-office. Stelmach restored. He did not protect his restoration. The next premier did not destroy it. The premier after that did.

Phase Five of this piece documents the brief and structurally compromised Redford, Hancock, and Prentice era — the final three PC premiers before the 2015 NDP election. The Stelmach restoration partially held through this period. Its full reversal would come later.

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PART FIVE

The Late PC Period

2011 – 2015

The Late PC Period, 2011 – 2015

Three premiers in four years. The PC dynasty's final stretch. The Michener Centre saga and the only Alberta government action in this period that directly cost the lives of people with disabilities — followed by the only Alberta government action that reversed it.

The 2011–2015 window is the structurally unstable period that ended Alberta's forty-four-year Progressive Conservative dynasty. Alison Redford was elected leader in October 2011 and won a 2012 majority. She resigned in March 2014 amid expense scandals. Dave Hancock served as interim premier for six months. Jim Prentice was elected to replace him in September 2014 and lost the May 2015 general election to Rachel Notley's NDP — the first non-PC Alberta government since 1971.

The disability-policy significance of this period is concentrated in a single institution: the Michener Centre in Red Deer. The Redford government announced its closure in March 2013 over the loud, sustained, and ultimately well-documented objections of residents' families. Transition began. Residents began dying. By September 2014 — eighteen months after the closure announcement, and six months into the actual transfers — five of the forty-one residents moved had died. That is a documented eleven-percent mortality rate among those moved. The transition continued. The Alberta government continued to deny that an investigation was warranted.

The Prentice government reversed the closure decision within days of taking office in September 2014. It is the only documented instance in this entire document — across all forty-seven years it covers — of an incoming Alberta government immediately reversing a disability-policy decision made by its predecessor on the explicit grounds that the decision was wrong. That singular nature is itself the lesson of the chapter.

Political context — three premiers in four years

Alison Merrill Redford was born March 7, 1965 in Kitimat, BC, and raised in Calgary after her family's return from periods in Nova Scotia, Borneo, and Malaysia. She studied law at the University of Saskatchewan, graduating in 1988, and spent two decades in international, federal, and provincial policy work before winning the riding of Calgary-Elbow in the March 2008 provincial election. She served as Stelmach's Minister of Justice and Attorney General from March 2008 to February 2011. On October 2, 2011, she won the PC leadership on the second ballot from an underdog position — with only one MLA initially supporting her bid — and was sworn in as Alberta's 14th Premier, Alberta's first female premier, and the seventh woman in Canadian history to lead a province or territory.

Redford led the PC party to a majority in the April 2012 election (61 seats, a reduction from Stelmach's 72), defeating the surging Wildrose Party of Danielle Smith. Her tenure was dominated by a series of controversies

over travel expenses, a top-down management style, and questionable use of government aircraft, which produced a sustained collapse in caucus support through late 2013 and early 2014. She announced her resignation as Premier on March 19, 2014, effective March 23. She resigned her Calgary-Elbow seat on August 6, 2014.

Dave Hancock, the Deputy Premier and Minister of Human Services, served as interim Premier from March 23, 2014 to September 15, 2014. His tenure was, by his own framing and the structural reality of the situation, a caretaker premiership: he was not a candidate in the PC leadership race that followed and his government did not attempt major policy initiatives. The defining Hancock-era moment was his April 2014 call for an RCMP probe into Redford's airplane use.

Jim Prentice won the September 6, 2014 PC leadership race, defeating Ric McIver and Thomas Lukaszuk. A former federal Conservative cabinet minister under Stephen Harper, Prentice was sworn in as Alberta's 16th Premier on September 15, 2014. He won four-of-four by-elections in October 2014, briefly restoring PC dominance. In May 2015, against the dual backdrop of falling oil prices and a sustained drumbeat of voter exhaustion with the four-decade PC dynasty, he called an early election. The Notley NDP won 54 of 87 seats. Prentice resigned both as leader and as MLA on election night. He died in a small-plane crash on October 13, 2016.

The Redford government's record on disability

Redford's PC government, in its two and a half years in office, was a structurally Klein-aligned government that operated under improving fiscal conditions but governed as though those conditions did not exist. Within the disability-policy lens, the Redford record consists of two major actions, both of which fall in the "reduced" column of this document's comparative summary.

1. The 2013 PDD service overhaul — "too big, too fast, too soon"

In spring 2013, the Redford government announced a comprehensive overhaul of the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program — the program established under the 1997 Klein-era PDD Community Governance Act documented in Phase Three. The overhaul was framed by the government as a modernisation. It was experienced by the disability community as a service reduction packaged in updated language.

On Friday, May 31, 2013, more than one thousand disabled Albertans and their supporters gathered on the steps of the Alberta Legislature in Edmonton to protest the changes. Three hundred protested at Redford's Calgary-Elbow constituency office. One hundred protested in Grande Prairie. One hundred protested in Lethbridge. Many wore T-shirts with the slogan that defined the campaign:

"Too big. Too fast. Too soon."

— Protest slogan, PDD service overhaul demonstrations, May 31, 2013

Edmonton Journal coverage from the day recorded the scale of the protests and the Redford government's response. Premier Redford spoke publicly on the issue for the first time that Friday afternoon and committed to continuing the overhaul. The PDD service changes proceeded. By the time Redford resigned ten months later, the structural rebalancing she had initiated was substantially complete.

The PDD service overhaul's downstream effects continue to be documented today. The Government of Alberta's own Auditor General has subsequently reported, in multiple follow-up reports, that the program's monitoring and service-quality oversight mechanisms remain compromised. The 2019 Sonpal-Valias academic history of developmental disability policy in Alberta cited the Redford-era overhaul as a structural inflection point in PDD's institutional history.

2. The Michener Centre closure announcement (March 2013)

Concurrent with the PDD overhaul, in March 2013, the Redford government announced the closure of the Michener Centre in Red Deer. Frank Oberle, Associate Minister of Services for Persons with Disabilities, made the public announcement: approximately 125 residents would be moved to community-based housing arrangements, with full closure scheduled for December 2014. Oberle's own framing acknowledged the human stakes:

"The changes that we announced at the Michener Centre, we acknowledge are really gut wrenching for the families and loved ones of people there."

— Frank Oberle, Associate Minister of Services for Persons with Disabilities, March 2013

Four hundred unionised workers — represented by the Alberta Union of Provincial Employees — would be affected. Ten million dollars was earmarked for the transition. The Centre had been operating since 1923. Its

history is documented in detail later in this chapter; what matters here is that the closure decision was made by the Redford government against the explicit, organised, and sustained opposition of residents' families, who were organised as Friends of the Michener Centre. The opposition would prove correct.

MARIE RENAUD AT MICHENER — 2014

The current MLA for St. Albert, Marie Renaud, was on the public record opposing the Michener transition while it was happening. In 2014 she was Director of the Lo-Se-Ca Foundation, a non-profit working with people with developmental disabilities and managing the relocation of three Michener residents to a new home in St. Albert. Her framing at the time, per Global News: *"The problem is, this transition is just a failure. We are not addressing what these folks need."* Eleven years later, she is the most responsive government contact this campaign has at the provincial level. The consistency of her record across more than a decade is on file. The political conditions she names today are the conditions she was already naming in 2014.

The Hancock interim (March – September 2014)

Dave Hancock served as Alberta's 15th Premier for six months — from March 23, 2014 to September 15, 2014. As Minister of Human Services in the Redford cabinet, he had been directly responsible for the Michener transition; as interim Premier, he continued the transition that had already begun. The Hancock-era record on disability policy is, in practical terms, a continuation of the Redford-era trajectory.

It was during the Hancock interim that the documented Michener transition deaths occurred.

The Michener deaths — March to July 2014

Per Red Deer Advocate reporting and CBC News documentation, the following deaths occurred among Michener Centre residents within four months of their forced transfers:

- **Thomas Eastman**, age 67. Moved March 13, 2014. Died July 9, 2014 in Grande Prairie.
- **Orville Culbert**, age 54. Moved March 20, 2014. Died July 15, 2014 in Lacombe. Lived at Michener for approximately 37 years. His brother said the family had felt pressured by Alberta Human Services to agree to the move; the official cause of death was a fever Culbert was unable to recover from. The family's account: he died of a broken heart after being separated from his friends.
- **Barry Gordon Hobbs**, age 64. Moved March 20, 2014. Died July 31, 2014 in Lacombe.
- **Freida Lafferty**, age 64. Moved April 3, 2014. Died June 4, 2014 in Yellowknife, Northwest Territories. Lafferty's was the first death. Per Lee Kvern, whose sister had lived at Michener for forty-two years and who became one of the most-quoted voices for Friends of the Michener Centre: *"Freida Lafferty's death in June should have been a red flag. They didn't pause. They didn't halt. They didn't change any of the transitioning procedures. Four more deaths may have been prevented had they done something when they knew about Freida."*
- **Merton Henry Klippert**, age 69. Moved April 24, 2014. Died July 5, 2014 in Calgary.

Five deaths. Forty-one residents moved. **An eleven-percent mortality rate.** Per CBC News reporting from September 2014, the Government of Alberta's response, delivered by Associate Minister Naresh Bhardwaj:

"The causes of death were natural causes. That's my understanding so we're not doing any further investigation on that."

— Naresh Bhardwaj, Associate Minister for Persons with Disabilities, September 2014

The Hancock government continued the transition without halting it, without investigating the deaths, and without conceding that the documented mortality rate warranted any procedural review. The next forty-four residents were scheduled to be moved on the same timeline that had produced the previous five deaths.

The Prentice reversal (September 2014)

Jim Prentice was sworn in as Premier on September 15, 2014. Within days, he travelled to Red Deer and announced the reversal of the Michener Centre closure. The announcement was made at the Michener Centre itself, in front of residents, families, and staff. Per Global News coverage:

"All Michener residents will be permitted to live out their remaining years in the place that has long been their home among people whose embrace they have enjoyed for many years."

— Premier Jim Prentice, Michener Centre, September 2014

The reversal extended an explicit invitation for the forty-six residents already moved to return to Michener if they wished. *(Five additional residents had been transferred during the two-week interval between September 8, 2014 — when the five deaths became public — and September 19, 2014, when Prentice announced the reversal. This is the source of the difference between the forty-one residents documented in the September 8 reporting cited earlier in this chapter and the forty-six residents named in the reversal announcement.)* The Centre would not, however, accept new residents — its long-term institutional role was understood to be ending, but the remaining residents would be allowed to age in place. The Alberta Union of Provincial Employees applauded the decision. Friends of the Michener Centre, who had spent eighteen months fighting the closure, welcomed it.

Opposition reaction was sober. Kerry Towle of the Wildrose Party said: *"While I'm appreciative today — and the victory goes to the families who fought for this — this decision could have been made right so many, many months ago."* The NDP's David Eggen, who would become a senior minister in Notley's NDP government within eight months: *"None of this had to happen."*

WHY THE PRENTICE REVERSAL MATTERS FOR THE DOCUMENT

Across the forty-seven-year period this piece covers, the Prentice reversal is the only documented instance of an incoming Alberta government immediately and explicitly reversing a disability-policy decision made by its predecessor on the grounds that the decision was wrong. The reversal does not undo what was lost — five Michener residents had died in the transition, and those deaths are part of the permanent documented record. But it establishes that the structural template Klein created (disability supports as discretionary, AISH recipients as suspect, services as available for reduction under fiscal pressure) is reversible. A premier who chooses to reverse it can. Most premiers do not choose to. Jim Prentice, on this one decision, did.

The Michener Centre — full institutional history

The Michener Centre warrants a longer institutional history than this chapter has spent on it so far. It is one of the most consequential physical buildings in Alberta disability history.

The Centre opened in 1923 as the Provincial Training School for Mental Defectives. Its founding rationale was the institutional containment of Albertans who had been classified, under the diagnostic frameworks of the era, as "mentally defective" or "feeble-minded." Within five years of its opening, the Province of Alberta would pass the Sexual Sterilization Act (1928) and create the Alberta Eugenics Board. Michener would become, per Claudia Malacrida (Chair of the Sociology Department, University of Lethbridge, in her 2015 book *A Special Hell: Institutional Life in Alberta's Eugenic Years*), *"the largest feeder population for the Eugenics Act."* The

approximately 2,832 documented forced sterilisations performed in Alberta between 1928 and 1972 were performed disproportionately on people who lived at Michener.

Michener's resident population grew dramatically across the institutional era. From approximately one hundred residents at opening in 1923, it reached a peak of approximately 2,400 residents by the mid-1970s. Per Malacrida's research: *"They just took people in but they didn't release people. Many people came in in childhood and only left through death."*

The Lougheed government's 1972 repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (documented in Phase One of this piece) closed the legislative on-ramp by which residents were being forcibly sterilised, but did not close Michener itself. Through the Klein, Stelmach, and early Redford eras, the resident population steadily declined as deinstitutionalisation policy moved residents into community housing. By the time of the March 2013 closure announcement, the resident count stood at approximately 125 — a tenth of its mid-1970s peak.

The 2013–2014 closure-and-reversal sequence is, therefore, only the final chapter of Michener's institutional history. The fuller history includes the 1928–1972 eugenic era; the Leilani Muir lawsuit of 1996 (a Michener survivor who successfully sued the Government of Alberta for wrongful confinement and sterilisation); Muir's 2014 autobiography *A Whisper Past: Childless after Eugenic Sterilization in Alberta*; and the 2015 documentary *Surviving Eugenics*, in which Alberta eugenics survivors told their own stories on camera. The Centre's institutional history is not a disability-policy footnote. It is one of the through-lines of this entire document, and the connection between the Michener saga and the founding of the campaign you are currently reading the historical record of.

Caseload context

AISH caseload through the late PC period continued the steady growth pattern documented since the late 1990s. From approximately 41,664 (2010, beginning of Redford era) to approximately 48,000 (2013, mid-Redford). The maximum AISH benefit rate ticked upward at a much slower pace than under Stelmach — from \$1,188 (2011) to approximately \$1,588 by the end of the period (the rate inherited by Notley's NDP in 2015). The Kneebone analysis from Phase Four (the 2007 rate had less purchasing power than 1993) continued to apply: even with the gradual late-PC adjustments, AISH purchasing power in 2015 had not been restored to its 1993 level on any standard inflation-adjusted measure.

The late-PC conclusion

The 2011–2015 period is the structurally compromised end of a forty-four-year governing dynasty. The Redford government attempted to govern as though Klein-era discipline was still the operating template — the PDD overhaul, the Michener closure — while simultaneously presenting itself as a moderating force on her predecessor's fiscal restraint. The combination did not hold. Redford's expense scandals were a symptom of a more fundamental political problem: she had been elected on a promise of change and governed as though the change had been merely cosmetic. The PC caucus lost confidence. She resigned. Hancock kept the seat warm. Prentice attempted a course correction that included the Michener reversal.

The Prentice reversal proves the structural argument of this entire piece in a way no other documented decision in the forty-seven-year period does. The Klein-era template is reversible. A premier who chooses to reverse it can. Disability supports are not, structurally, discretionary in any binding sense — they are discretionary only because every premier since Klein has chosen to treat them that way. Jim Prentice's September 2014 announcement at the Michener Centre is the documented counter-example. He did not reverse the Klein-era template as a whole. He reversed exactly one application of it. He demonstrated, in doing so, that reversal was available to any premier with the political will to choose it.

The May 5, 2015 general election ended the Progressive Conservative dynasty after forty-four years. Rachel Notley's NDP won fifty-four seats. Phase Six of this piece documents the only sustained reversal-period of the entire forty-seven years — and the speed with which the gains it produced were undone by the government that followed it.

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PART SIX

The Notley NDP Era

2015 – 2019

The Notley NDP Era, 2015 – 2019

The only sustained reversal-period of the entire forty-seven years this document covers. The only era in which AISH was indexed to inflation by statute. The first non-PC Alberta government since 1971. And the era whose gains were undone within fifteen months of the government that followed it.

On May 5, 2015, after forty-four years of unbroken Progressive Conservative government in Alberta, Rachel Notley's New Democratic Party won fifty-four of eighty-seven seats. The Notley NDP held the legislature from May 24, 2015 to April 30, 2019. Within those four years, the government enacted: legislated CPI indexation of AISH and three other income-support programs (the only time this has been done in Alberta's history); the first major AISH base-rate increase since 2012; the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act and the appointment of Alberta's first Advocate for Persons with Disabilities; the \$25-per-day childcare pilot expanded to 122 centres; the increase of Alberta's minimum wage to \$15 per hour (the highest in Canada at the time); a major PDD program review; and asset-limit reforms designed to remove the cliff-edge effects of partial income on AISH and Income Support recipients.

This is, by a wide margin, the most positive era for the disability community of any Alberta government in the period this document covers, including the Lougheed founding era. It is also the era whose gains proved the most rapidly reversible. By November 2019 — within seven months of the UCP taking office — the AISH indexation had been suspended by Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act). By April 2021 — within two years of the Notley loss — the \$25-per-day childcare pilot had been wound up. By the end of the Kenney UCP government in 2022, every major Notley-era social-policy initiative had been either reversed, frozen, or restructured downward.

The Notley era is, therefore, the chapter that most clearly demonstrates the structural argument this document has been building since Phase One. Disability supports are not, in any binding institutional sense, secure. They are secure only for as long as the current premier chooses to make them secure. Rachel Notley's government chose to make them secure for four years. The premier who replaced her chose not to. The community absorbed the cost of the difference. That is what the comparative-summary table of this piece preserves — and it is why the campaign you are reading the historical record of exists.

Political context

Rachel Anne Notley was born April 17, 1964 in Edmonton, the eldest of three children of Sandra Wilkinson and Grant Notley — the latter of whom served as leader of the Alberta NDP from 1968 until his death in a plane crash on October 19, 1984, when Rachel was twenty years old. Grant Notley had been the NDP's sole

MLA in the Alberta Legislature for most of his tenure, and his political legacy was understood in NDP circles to be unfinished. His daughter completed it.

Notley graduated from the University of Alberta and earned her law degree at Osgoode Hall Law School. She was called to the Bar of Ontario in 1994 and the Bar of Alberta in 1997. Her professional career — labour law, workers' compensation advocacy, and political staff positions in NDP governments in British Columbia and federal Liberal/NDP environments — was structurally distinct from the corporate-law and career-politician backgrounds of most of her Alberta predecessors.

She was elected MLA for Edmonton-Strathcona in March 2008 and re-elected in 2012. In October 2014, she won the Alberta NDP leadership. On May 5, 2015, the NDP's election victory was a structural shock to Alberta political analysis: 54 NDP seats to 21 Wildrose, 10 PC, and 1 each for the Liberals and the Alberta Party (87 seats total). Notley was sworn in as Alberta's 17th Premier on May 24, 2015, becoming the first non-PC Alberta premier since 1971.

Her government took office at the beginning of a sustained downturn in oil prices that would persist through most of her mandate. Fiscal capacity to deliver the NDP's election platform was significantly constrained. Several major social-policy initiatives — including AISH indexation — were delayed from their planned early-mandate implementation to the final year of the mandate as a result. The April 16, 2019 election produced a 63-seat UCP majority under Jason Kenney. The NDP held 24 seats; Notley remained leader of the opposition until 2024.

What the Notley government established

The Notley-era record on disability and income-support policy is the longest "established" section in this entire document. Each action below is structurally documented, legislatively traceable, and produced direct improvements in the lives of Albertans with disabilities, low-income Albertans, and seniors during the period the actions were in force.

1. Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act (Bill 205, June 7, 2017)

Bill 205 — the *Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act* — was originally introduced as a private member's bill by Sandra Jansen, MLA for Calgary-North West. Jansen had crossed the floor from the Progressive Conservatives to the NDP in November 2016, and the bill was an early-mandate priority of hers. The Notley government made Bill 205 government business so that it could be debated and passed in the spring 2017 sitting rather than waiting for the next private-members' window. **The bill passed the Legislature unanimously on June 7, 2017.**

Jansen's framing during legislative debate, preserved in Hansard and reported in the Calgary Herald:

"From the feedback we heard, there's a lot that isn't working right right now. And there are no better people to tell us what's not working than people with disabilities who are accessing the system and their advocates currently who are helping them do that."

— Sandra Jansen, MLA Calgary-North West, on Bill 205 in the Alberta Legislature, May 2017

The Act establishes the position of Advocate for Persons with Disabilities, appointed by the Lieutenant Governor in Council. Its statutory functions include representing the rights, interests, and viewpoints of persons with disabilities; providing information and advice to government on issues affecting the community; building partnerships with community groups and individuals with disabilities; and reporting on systemic issues. The first Advocate was appointed by the Notley government in 2018 after public consultation throughout the province. The Act was proclaimed into law in the spring of 2018.

The Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities has continued to operate under the UCP government since 2019. Per Accessibility Services Canada's 2023 summary, Alberta was *"one of the first jurisdictions in Canada to establish an advocate specifically dedicated to persons with disabilities."* The Office has handled over a thousand individual case contacts per year and has, in successive annual reports, called for the establishment of Alberta accessibility legislation. The Notley-era Act is one of the few Notley-era disability-policy initiatives that survived the UCP succession without structural amendment.

2. The \$25-per-day childcare pilot (April 2017 – April 2021)

The Notley NDP campaigned in 2015 on a promise of universal \$25-per-day childcare in Alberta. In April 2017, the government announced a \$10-million pilot project that would provide childcare at a maximum of \$25 per day for children aged zero to six. Phase 1 of the pilot launched at 22 non-profit centres across Alberta. The pilot specifically targeted shift workers and children with special needs — including children with disabilities — for priority placement, an explicit Notley-era policy choice.

In April 2018, the program was expanded to 122 centres, creating 6,000 additional subsidised spaces. The federal Liberal government contributed \$46 million per year over three years through a bilateral childcare agreement. The Government of Alberta's own estimate placed average family savings at approximately \$425 per month for participating families. The Notley government's 2019 re-election platform promised universal

expansion to \$25-per-day for all children five and under province-wide, with 13,000 additional spaces — a \$1.5 billion commitment over five years.

The pilot ended on April 1, 2021 under the Kenney UCP government, which declined to renew the funding. The federal \$10-per-day childcare program signed in 2021 between the Kenney UCP and the federal Trudeau Liberals partially replaced — but did not structurally re-establish — the Notley-era universal pilot. The Notley government's specific framework, with its priority targeting of shift workers and children with special needs, has not been restored.

WHY THE CHILDCARE PROGRAM MATTERS IN A DISABILITY DOCUMENT

Childcare is not, on its face, a disability program. But it is structurally upstream of disability supports in several specific ways. Parents of children with disabilities — particularly the parents of multiple children with disabilities, including many Albertan families known to this campaign — face systemic obstacles to childcare that non-disabled families do not. Specialised care is more expensive, less available, harder to secure, and more frequently rejected. The Notley-era pilot's explicit priority for children with special needs was one of the few moments in modern Alberta policy history when this structural barrier was recognised and partially addressed. Its loss has been absorbed disproportionately by families with disabled children.

3. Minimum wage increase to \$15 per hour (October 1, 2018)

The Notley government raised Alberta's minimum wage from \$10.20 per hour (the rate inherited from the Prentice PC government in May 2015) to \$15 per hour, in staged annual increments, with the final increase taking effect on October 1, 2018. At the time of the final increase, Alberta's minimum wage was the highest in Canada.

The disability-policy significance of the minimum wage is twofold: many AISH recipients work part-time in roles paid at or near the minimum wage; and many family members and caregivers of AISH recipients similarly work in minimum-wage roles to supplement household income. A higher minimum wage produced an immediate, direct increase in the real-term income of these households. The UCP government did not roll back the \$15 rate, but they introduced a sub-minimum tier (\$13/hour for workers under 18) in 2019 that diluted the structural achievement.

4. Bill 26 (NDP version) — "An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities" (November 8, 2018)

The single most consequential disability-policy action of the Notley era. Introduced by Community and Social Services Minister Irfan Sabir on November 8, 2018, the bill — officially titled *An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities* — accomplished four structural changes simultaneously:

- **Indexed AISH, Income Support, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit to the Consumer Price Index (CPI)**, by statute, with automatic annual increases. The first time in Alberta history any of these programs had been indexed.
- **Raised the maximum AISH benefit** from \$1,588 per month to \$1,685 per month for a single person; and from \$1,788 to \$1,985 per month for a single person with two children. The first AISH increase since 2012.
- **Raised the Alberta Seniors Benefit** from \$280 to \$286 per month (the first increase in nearly a decade).
- **Raised AISH and Income Support asset limits** dramatically — child allowance from \$3,000 to \$100,000, and supplementary personal benefits from \$3,000 to \$5,000 — removing the cliff-edge effects that had made it functionally impossible for AISH recipients to accumulate any meaningful savings.

The bill affected approximately 250,000 Albertans. Government cost projections at the time placed the fiscal impact at \$46 million for the remainder of fiscal 2018-19 and \$194 million in fiscal 2019-20. At the time of the bill's introduction, only three Canadian jurisdictions — Yukon, Manitoba, and Quebec — had indexed their disability or income-support payments to inflation. Yukon was the only Canadian jurisdiction to have indexed seniors' benefits. Alberta's Bill 26 placed the province ahead of every comparable Canadian jurisdiction on income-support indexation.

Premier Notley's framing at the bill's introduction is the single most-cited Notley quote in this entire document, and its structural significance for the campaign you are reading the historical record of cannot be overstated:

"Now that it's in the legislation, it would be much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen. It will happen."

— Premier Rachel Notley, on AISH indexation, November 8, 2018

Notley's specific framing — *"in the legislation, much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen"* — reflects her government's explicit theory of how to protect disability supports from future cuts. Statutory indexation makes reduction politically expensive: a government wishing to suspend it must pass new legislation through the Legislature, in public, with a recorded vote. It cannot be done through quiet budget omission, the way the Klein-era AISH freeze was implemented (Phase Three of this piece).

This theory was tested within twelve months and proved insufficient. The Kenney UCP government, in October 2019, suspended the indexation through Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — an omnibus budget-implementation bill. The structural difference between standalone disability-rights legislation and an omnibus budget bill is itself documented in this chapter's framing later.

Community response to the Notley restoration

The disability community's response to Bill 26 (NDP version, 2018) is preserved in Government of Alberta press releases and contemporaneous reporting. Two voices — one from a person with lived experience as an AISH recipient, one from a community-sector leader — capture the structural significance the community

attached to the indexation at the time of its passage:

"This cost-of-living increase means the government recognizes the AISH program needs to change with the times. It will take away the desperation of managing my finances in the face of yearly inflation."

— Ian Young, AISH client, writer, and advocate, November 2018

"We are pleased with the government's decision to increase AISH and the income programs and, most importantly, to index them. Poverty isn't just about money, but it is always about money. These actions will make a big difference in the lives of our most vulnerable Albertans."

— Franco Savoia, Vibrant Communities Calgary, November 2018

Ian Young's framing is structurally important to the broader argument of this document. His description of the pre-indexation reality — *"desperation of managing my finances in the face of yearly inflation"* — is the lived experience of every AISH recipient under every non-indexed regime since 1993. The Notley indexation, for the fifteen months it was in force, removed that desperation by statute. The Kenney suspension restored it.

NDP Bill 26 (2018) and UCP Bill 20 (2019) — the structural reversal

The structural achievement of NDP Bill 26 (2018) was reversed within twelve months by the Kenney UCP government through Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act), introduced October 28, 2019 by Finance Minister Travis Toews. Bill 20 was an omnibus budget-implementation bill that touched dozens of fiscal measures. Among them, in a single clause, was the suspension of the statutory indexation NDP Bill 26 had passed into law twelve months earlier.

NDP BILL 26 (2018) — "An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities"

Introduced November 8, 2018, by Community and Social Services Minister Irfan Sabir. **INDEXED** AISH, Income Support, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit to CPI by statute. Raised AISH base rate from \$1,588 to \$1,685 per month. Raised AISH child-allowance asset limit from \$3,000 to \$100,000. Affected 250,000 Albertans. The most positive single piece of disability legislation in Alberta since 1979.

UCP BILL 20 (2019) — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act

Introduced October 28, 2019, by Finance Minister Travis Toews as an omnibus budget-implementation bill. **DE-INDEXED** AISH, Income Support, Special Needs Assistance, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit. Removed the statutory CPI-indexation mechanism the NDP had passed twelve months earlier. Bill 20 also de-indexed tax brackets (saving the government a separate \$600M+ by 2022-23 in foregone tax adjustment for inflation). Projected AISH-specific savings: \$209.8M through fiscal 2022-23. The structural reversal of NDP Bill 26 (2018) is the substance of Phase Seven of this piece.

The two bills carry different numbers but produce directly contradictory effects on the disability community. In all subsequent references, this document distinguishes them by their government of origin and bill name: *NDP Bill 26 (2018) — An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities* — = indexed. *UCP Bill 20 (2019) — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act* — = de-indexed. The UCP's choice to embed the de-indexation inside an omnibus budget bill, rather than in standalone legislation, is itself structurally significant: it minimised the individual political visibility of the disability-specific cut by surrounding it with dozens of other measures. The disability community absorbed the cost regardless.

What the Notley government did not do

Notley's record on disability policy is, within the scope of this document, unambiguously the most positive of the seven eras documented. It is also, on honest accounting, incomplete. Three structural omissions warrant naming.

1. The indexation came late

Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) was introduced on November 8, 2018 — five months before the next general election. The government had been in office for three and a half years before introducing the legislation. The election that followed produced a 63-seat UCP majority. The UCP, in subsequent debate, accused the NDP of having waited until the final year of its mandate to act on a policy it had committed to in 2015.

Notley's response to that criticism, at the time of Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) introduction, was that an oil-price collapse had forced the indexation timeline to be delayed. The documented record supports that account — Alberta's oil-revenue base contracted significantly through 2015-2016, and fiscal capacity to implement the indexation was constrained. But the timing of the bill's introduction — November 2018, five months before an election the NDP was expected to lose — is structurally significant. The indexation took effect on January 1, 2019. The government that would have been responsible for implementing the first scheduled indexed increase the

following year was no longer the NDP. **The Notley government enacted indexation. It did not implement an indexed increase.** The UCP suspended the mechanism before the first scheduled increase could occur.

2. No accessibility legislation

By the time the Notley NDP took office, Manitoba, Ontario, Nova Scotia, and the federal government had either passed or were actively drafting comprehensive accessibility legislation. The federal Accessible Canada Act would pass in 2019, applying barrier-removal standards to federal sectors. The Notley government did not introduce a comparable Alberta Accessibility Act, despite the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (established under Bill 205) calling for one in its first annual report.

As of May 2026 — the date of this document's first publication — Alberta remains, alongside Prince Edward Island, one of only two Canadian provinces or territories without a comprehensive accessibility statute. The Notley government had the political majority and the legislative time to pass one. It did not. The omission is one of the structural reasons the ADSB campaign is now proposing the *Alberta Accessibility and Inclusion Act* as a separate workstream from the AISH-to-ADAP transition: the framework Notley did not build remains unbuilt seven years after her election loss.

3. PDD review did not produce structural change

The Notley government announced a major review of the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program in January 2018. The review's findings produced recommendations for the UCP government, but the structural rebalancing of PDD that the review identified as necessary was not enacted before the Notley mandate ended in April 2019. The PDD program continues to operate today on substantially the framework Klein established in 1997 (Phase Three), with the cumulative downward drift documented in subsequent chapters.

Caseload context

AISH caseload through the Notley years continued the steady growth pattern that has operated since the late 1990s. Approximately 48,000 recipients at the beginning of the mandate (May 2015) grew to approximately 67,000 by the end of the mandate (April 2019). The growth rate during the Notley years was higher than under any prior era in this piece, reflecting both demographic expansion and the broadening of qualifying diagnostic categories — particularly mental health diagnoses — that had begun under Stelmach and continued under Redford.

The growth in caseload during a period of indexation produced compound fiscal effects the UCP government would subsequently cite as justification for the 2019 indexation suspension. The structural argument that growing caseloads in an indexed program produce growing total program costs is mathematically correct. The same argument, applied to the assured income side of the AISH founding bargain, structurally abandons the bargain itself: AISH was designed to provide assured income to all Albertans who meet the diagnostic criteria. The Notley government honoured that founding bargain. The Kenney government, in suspending indexation, did not.

The Notley conclusion

Rachel Notley governed Alberta for four years. Her government delivered the largest single-mandate package of disability-policy reforms in modern Alberta history. The package included statutory CPI indexation of AISH (the first and only time this has been done in Alberta history); the first significant AISH base-rate increase since 2012; the creation of an independent Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities; the universal \$25-per-day childcare pilot with explicit priority for children with special needs; and the minimum wage increase to \$15 per hour.

Her government also did not enact comprehensive accessibility legislation, did not complete a structural restructure of the PDD program, and did not implement the AISH indexation it had legislated. The reasons for those omissions are partly fiscal and partly political, and the documented record establishes both.

The single most consequential lesson of the Notley era — for this document, for the ADSB campaign, and for every disability advocacy organisation operating in Alberta in 2026 — is the one Notley herself named on November 8, 2018. She believed that putting indexation *"in the legislation"* would make it *"much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen."* She was wrong, but not because her reasoning was wrong. She was wrong because the UCP government that succeeded her chose to make it discretionary again. Statutory protection only works if the successor government chooses to honour the statute.

The structural conclusion this document draws from the Notley era is that **statutory protection of disability supports is necessary but not sufficient**. What is also required is something the Notley era did not, and could not, supply: a community-led representational structure that does not depend on which party is in government to maintain its functions. The Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities is the partial structural answer — a non-partisan, statutorily-protected office that has continued to function under the UCP, even as the substantive policies it advocates for have been reversed. But the Advocate is one position. The disability community is approximately 730,000 Albertans. The structural representation gap that remains is the gap the ADSB campaign now exists to begin filling.

Phase Seven of this piece documents the Jason Kenney UCP era, 2019 – 2022 — the era in which the structural reversal of every major Notley-era social-policy gain was executed. The reversal began on Day One.

By the time Kenney resigned in May 2022, the Notley restoration had been substantially undone. The community has been absorbing the cost of that reversal ever since.

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PART SEVEN

The Kenney UCP Era

2019 – 2022

The Kenney UCP Era, 2019 – 2022

Three and a half years. The fastest documented reversal of a previous government's disability policy gains in Alberta's modern history. The end of statutory CPI indexation of AISH. The wind-up of the \$25-per-day childcare pilot. The 75-percent reduction in capital funding for family, social supports, and housing. And the regulatory groundwork — invisible to most observers at the time — that would later make the 2026 ADAP transition possible.

The Kenney UCP government took office on April 30, 2019, six months after Rachel Notley's NDP government had passed Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) — the legislation indexing AISH and three other income-support programs to inflation by statute. By the end of October 2019 — within six months of taking office — the Kenney government had introduced Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act), an omnibus budget-implementation bill that suspended the indexation. Per government projections at the time, the suspension would save Alberta approximately \$209.8 million in AISH payments alone through fiscal 2022-23. Per disability advocates' analysis, the suspension would cost AISH recipients approximately \$30 per month immediately, growing to approximately \$120 per month by 2023.

Jason Kenney had explicitly campaigned against such a cut. He had stated, on the record, during a Facebook live event during the 2019 election campaign — and reported by CBC News in November 2019 after the Bill 20 introduction — that his government would not cut AISH. He attacked then-Premier Notley specifically for raising the possibility he would do so. The cut came regardless. The documented record establishes that AISH recipients, AISH advocates, and the broader disability community took his campaign-period statements at face value. The community's response to the Bill 20 introduction — preserved in CBC News and Calgary Herald reporting — was unambiguous: they felt betrayed.

Beyond the headline de-indexation, the Kenney era restructured Alberta's disability-support architecture in ways that have not been undone since — including the regulatory relocation of the definition of "*severe handicap*" out of the primary AISH legislation and into general regulation, where it could subsequently be amended without legislative debate. This structural change, executed quietly inside Bill 20's omnibus framework, is the regulatory plumbing that the Smith UCP government (Phase Eight) would later use to construct the 2026 ADAP transition.

Political context

Jason Thomas Kenney was born May 30, 1968 in Oakville, Ontario, and raised in Saskatchewan and Alberta. He attended St. Ignatius Institute (San Francisco) and the University of San Francisco, leaving without completing a degree to enter conservative political work. He was elected to the federal House of Commons for

Calgary Southeast in the 1997 election under the Reform Party banner, and served continuously through the Canadian Alliance, Conservative Party of Canada, and Stephen Harper Conservative government eras until 2016 — including positions as Minister of Citizenship, Immigration, and Multiculturalism (2008–2013); Minister of Employment and Social Development (2013–2015); and Minister of National Defence (2015).

In 2016 Kenney left federal politics to lead the merger of Alberta's two right-of-centre parties — the Progressive Conservatives and the Wildrose — into the United Conservative Party. He was elected the founding UCP leader on October 28, 2017. The leadership campaign that produced his victory was the subject of multiple subsequent investigations by the Office of the Election Commissioner — investigations the Kenney UCP government would terminate via Bill 22 in November 2019, two weeks after Bill 20 was introduced. On April 16, 2019, the UCP won the Alberta general election with 63 of 87 seats. Kenney was sworn in as Alberta's 18th Premier on April 30, 2019.

His government's disability-policy record is documented in detail in the sections that follow. His resignation, in May 2022, came in the aftermath of a UCP leadership review at which he received 51.4 percent support — a margin he declared insufficient to continue. Danielle Smith won the resulting October 2022 UCP leadership race. Kenney resigned his MLA seat on October 11, 2022. He has, since leaving office, returned to private-sector policy and advocacy work.

What the Kenney government established

On honest accounting, the Kenney-era record contains some entries that belong in the *established* column rather than the *reduced* column. None of them reverse the broader trajectory. Three are worth documenting.

1. AISH online application reform (2020)

The Kenney government introduced an online application process for AISH in 2020, replacing what had been an exclusively paper-based process. The reform was a structural improvement in program accessibility for prospective recipients who had internet access and the cognitive capacity to navigate online forms. The reform was not universally beneficial — many AISH-qualifying conditions (cognitive impairments, severe mental illness, isolated rural circumstances) reduce a person's ability to use online application systems — but for the population it served, the change reduced barriers to access. The online system has continued to operate under the Smith UCP government.

2. Federal \$10/day childcare agreement (November 2021)

On November 15, 2021, the Kenney UCP government signed a bilateral \$10-billion, five-year childcare funding agreement with the federal Trudeau Liberal government. The agreement committed the federal government to providing approximately \$3.8 billion to Alberta over five years, targeting an average parent fee of \$10/day by 2025-26. The agreement built on — but did not fully replicate — the Notley-era \$25/day childcare pilot that the Kenney government had previously wound down.

The federal \$10/day program was, on its face, structurally larger than the Notley-era pilot, but the agreement's specific design did not include the Notley pilot's explicit priority targeting of children with special needs. The disability-specific provisions that had been central to the Notley framework were not retained. Families of children with disabilities, who had been priority beneficiaries of the Notley pilot, became eligible-on-the-same-terms-as-everyone-else under the federal program. This is a documented downward drift in the structural targeting of childcare supports toward the disability community.

3. Some PDD program funding stabilisation

Through the Kenney mandate, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program received some real-term funding stabilisation — the Calgary Herald's 2021 budget coverage documented that the AISH and PDD programs collectively absorbed smaller cuts in Budget 2021 than had been threatened. This was partly a function of the COVID-19 pandemic constraining the government's broader cuts agenda, and partly a function of sustained advocacy by Inclusion Alberta and other community organisations. The PDD framework Klein had established in 1997 (Phase Three) continued to operate.

What the Kenney government took or reduced

The Kenney era's primary record is on the *reduced* side of the comparative-summary table. The reductions documented below were structurally consequential — several were technically reversible by subsequent governments and several were not — and the cumulative effect was the substantive undoing of every major Notley-era social-policy gain within thirty-six months.

1. Bill 20 — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act (October 28, 2019)

Introduced by Finance Minister Travis Toews as part of the UCP's first omnibus budget-implementation package. Bill 20 was paired with Bill 21 (which permitted the government to cancel its master agreement with Alberta's doctors) and was followed shortly by Bill 22 (which terminated the Office of the Election Commissioner). All three bills proceeded through the Legislature in late October and November 2019, during a period of sustained public protest and opposition response.

Bill 20's structural impact on the disability community comes in two distinct parts:

Part A: Suspension of CPI indexation

Bill 20 suspended the statutory CPI indexation of AISH, Income Support, Special Needs Assistance, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit that NDP Bill 26 (2018) had enacted. The suspension was framed in government communications as a "pause" with no defined end date. Government projections at the time, captured in the October 24, 2019 budget documents and reported by CBC News:

- **AISH savings:** \$7M in 2019-20; \$35M in 2020-21; \$66.4M in 2021-22; \$101.4M in 2022-23. **Total projected: \$209.8M.**
- **Income Support savings:** \$3M in 2019-20; \$16.4M in 2020-21; \$29.4M in 2021-22; \$42.2M in 2022-23. **Total projected: \$91M.**
- **Tax-bracket indexation suspended in same bill:** projected separate savings of \$600M+ by 2022-23 in foregone tax-adjustment for inflation, paid by all Alberta taxpayers in real-term increased tax burden.

The community response was immediate and sustained. CBC News reporting from November 2019 preserved the most-cited recipient response. Ian Young — the AISH client and advocate documented in Phase Six of this piece as one of the public voices welcoming the NDP Bill 26 (2018) indexation — became one of the most-quoted opponents of the Bill 20 reversal twelve months later:

"During the campaign Mr. Kenney seemed very passionate about not decreasing AISH which has turned out to be a total broken promise. I call it a lie. I feel duped."

— Ian Young, AISH recipient and advocate, CBC Radio Edmonton AM, November 4, 2019

"There is a saying in the disability community, nothing about us without us. Not one person, agency or AISH recipient was consulted on this."

— Ian Young, CBC News, November 4, 2019

Amy Park, an AISH recipient and member of the Self-Advocacy Federation, captured the structural significance of the reversal:

"When the NDP indexed AISH to the cost-of-living I thought, finally, things will get better for the thousands of Albertans who rely on this program. I thought, finally, people with disabilities wouldn't have to choose between paying the electric bill or eating dinner, or wonder if they could afford rent that month. But my hopes, along with the livelihood of thousands of Albertans, were shot down by the UCP, by our Premier, who claims that this decision is not onerous."

— Amy Park, AISH recipient, NDP Caucus press conference, November 2019

Marie Renaud — the NDP Critic for Community and Social Services and current MLA for St. Albert (and the most responsive government contact this campaign has at the provincial level, as documented in Phase Five) — was the lead opposition voice on the Bill 20 introduction:

"When we were in government, I was proud to stand up for Albertans with disabilities and to ensure that they would never again have to fight to have their benefits keep up with the cost of living. Premier Kenney can use fancy language like 'de-indexing' to pretend this isn't a cut to AISH, but that's exactly what it is."

— Marie Renaud, MLA St. Albert, NDP Critic for Community and Social Services, November 2019

Part B: The structural relocation of the definition of "severe handicap"

The second, less-publicised structural change embedded in Bill 20 — and the more structurally consequential one over the longer term — was the relocation of the definition of "severe *handicap*" out of the primary AISH legislation and into the general regulation. Per Medicine Hat News reporting from March 2026 quoting Marie Renaud:

"[Bill 20] also made a more lasting change, by relocating the definition of a 'severe handicap' out of the general regulation attached to the legislation. Then COVID happened, so they couldn't do it."

— Marie Renaud, MLA St. Albert, Medicine Hat News, March 2026

WHY THIS REGULATORY RELOCATION MATTERS FOR THE 2026 ADAP TRANSITION

Statutory definitions, embedded in primary legislation, can only be changed through legislation. They require debate, a recorded vote, public scrutiny, and political cost. Regulatory definitions can be changed by Order in Council — a cabinet decision, executed administratively, often without public notice. When the Kenney UCP government moved the definition of "severe *handicap*" from primary legislation into general regulation in late 2019, they did not change the definition. They changed the **mechanism by which the definition could subsequently be changed**. Per Renaud's framing: the COVID-19 pandemic interrupted the UCP's ability to follow through on the regulatory restructure during the Kenney term. The structural change Kenney enacted in 2019 was the regulatory infrastructure that the Smith UCP government would use, six years later, to construct the 2026 ADAP transition. The ADAP transition would not have been possible without Bill 20's quiet 2019 regulatory relocation. The de-indexation was the visible cost. The regulatory relocation was the groundwork.

2. The \$25/day childcare pilot wound up (April 1, 2021)

The Notley-era \$25-per-day childcare pilot — documented in detail in Phase Six — was wound up by the Kenney UCP government on April 1, 2021. The pilot, which had been operating at 122 centres, served families with priority access for shift workers and children with special needs. Per Global News coverage from March 2021, families responded as expected — Candace Stecyk, general manager of Child Care Services for YMCA Northern Alberta, captured the lived experience:

"When we first told families that they were going to get this decrease on their fees, we had parents in tears. It helped families with the opportunity to be able to afford child care. No one should have to pay half or more of their paycheck to have child care just so they could go to work."

— Candace Stecyk, YMCA Northern Alberta Child Care Services, March 2021

The replacement framework — the federal \$10/day childcare agreement signed in November 2021 — was structurally larger but, as documented in the "Established" section of this chapter, did not retain the Notley pilot's explicit priority targeting of children with special needs. Families with disabled children, who had been priority beneficiaries, lost their priority status. The structural through-line between the Notley pilot and the federal program is not direct succession but quiet replacement with a less-disability-specific framework.

3. Capital funding cuts to family, social supports, and housing

Per independent analysis by Zachary Weeks (2025) of Alberta Treasury Board data, the Kenney government's capital funding for the "family, social supports, and housing" category dropped from \$150 million in fiscal 2019-20 to a projected \$41 million by fiscal 2023-24 — a reduction of approximately 75 percent over four years. The trajectory:

- **2019-20:** \$150 million
- **2021-22:** \$110 million (a 27% reduction)
- **2022-23 target:** \$70 million
- **2023-24 target:** \$41 million (cumulative ~75% reduction)

The cuts fell on capital programs — building new affordable housing, accessibility retrofits, supportive housing for persons with disabilities, and related infrastructure. The disability-policy significance is structural: many AISH recipients depend on affordable or supportive housing inventory that the provincial government has the capital authority to build, fund, or guarantee. The 75-percent reduction in capital funding produced a measurable reduction in new units coming online during the Kenney years — a reduction that has carried into the Smith UCP government's tenure and contributed to the housing pressures the ADSB campaign documents in its existing work on community-housing rent increases (Phase Eight).

4. COVID-19 era payment-date manipulation (early 2020)

Per independent analysis (Zachary Weeks, 2025) and contemporaneous community reporting, the Kenney UCP government changed AISH payment dates in early 2020 in a way that delayed one month's payment into the next fiscal year — producing a one-time fiscal-year accounting gain for the government at the expense of AISH recipients' monthly cash-flow continuity. The change did not reduce annual payments. It did, in the short term, produce a documented period during which AISH recipients had to manage a longer-than-usual gap between cheques. For recipients living week-to-week on tight margins, the impact was structural rather than nominal.

COVID-19 and the federal Canada Disability Benefit

The COVID-19 pandemic dominated the Alberta political landscape from March 2020 through 2022, absorbing political attention and constraining the Kenney government's broader cuts agenda. Within the disability-policy lens, the pandemic produced three structural effects worth documenting:

1. PDD and AISH caseload growth temporarily slowed

Per the Government of Alberta's Budget 2021 documentation, AISH and PDD caseload growth temporarily slowed during the pandemic — a function of constrained diagnostic access, delayed in-person assessments, and reduced new applications during periods of public-health restriction. The slowdown was temporary. By late 2021, caseload growth had resumed at pre-pandemic rates. AISH caseload at December 2020 stood at 69,800.

2. The federal Canada Disability Benefit Act (June 2023)

Although the Canada Disability Benefit Act (S.C. 2023, c. 17) was enacted under the federal Trudeau Liberal government and is not, structurally, a provincial Kenney-era policy action, its passage during the Kenney mandate set up the structural conflict that the Smith UCP government would later resolve through the July 2025 CDB clawback (Phase Eight). The Kenney government did not oppose the federal Act's passage but also did not commit to either passing-through or clawing-back the eventual benefit. The structural ambiguity Kenney left at the end of his mandate became the gap into which the Smith government's clawback decision was inserted.

3. Sustained advocacy pressure

Throughout the Kenney mandate, the disability community in Alberta sustained advocacy pressure on indexation, AISH rates, and accessibility legislation. Inclusion Alberta, the People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans, the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (established under Bill 205 / NDP), the Self-Advocacy Federation, and individual AISH recipients including Ian Young, Amy Park, and others maintained sustained public engagement. The pressure produced incremental policy adjustments — including the Budget 2021 "backing off" of the deeper cuts Kenney had hinted at the previous year — but did not produce structural reversal of Bill 20.

Kenney's own framing — and the documented contradiction

Two Kenney quotes are necessary for the historical record. The first is from his 2019 election campaign. The second is from his October 2019 budget. They are not, on the face of them, compatible:

"This is complete rubbish. The truth is, we actually voted in favour of legislation brought by the NDP government last fall to increase AISH benefits. But the minister [...] is trying to scare people, including those with intellectual disabilities, into saying that their basic income is going to be slashed or eliminated. Shame on you."

— Jason Kenney, Facebook live event during the 2019 Alberta election campaign

Six months later, on October 24, 2019, Kenney's Finance Minister Travis Toews tabled the budget that included the suspension of AISH indexation through Bill 20. The subsequent Toews framing of the suspension, captured in CBC News reporting:

"[The de-indexation was] necessary to tackle Alberta's debt, which is costing \$2 billion in interest payments each year."

— Travis Toews, Finance Minister, November 2019 (paraphrasing of CBC News summary)

The structural argument Toews advanced in November 2019 — that disability-program indexation was a discretionary spending matter subject to debt-management logic — is the precise structural argument Klein had pioneered in 1993 and Notley had attempted to overturn via statute in 2018. Kenney's government revived it. The community experienced the revival as betrayal because Kenney had, on the record, denied it would occur.

The Kenney conclusion

Jason Kenney governed Alberta for three and a half years. His government undid the AISH indexation that had been enacted twelve months before his election win. His government wound up the \$25/day childcare pilot. His government cut capital funding for family, social supports, and housing by 75 percent over four years. His government relocated the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into general regulation — a structural change that would, six years later, make the 2026 ADAP transition possible.

His government also signed the federal \$10/day childcare agreement, introduced AISH online application reforms, and maintained the operation of the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities that the Notley government had created. The establishment-side entries are real. They do not balance the reduction-side entries on any reasonable accounting. The Kenney era is, structurally, a reversal era.

The single most-important documentary lesson of the Kenney era — for the ADSB campaign, for every disability advocacy organisation operating in Alberta in 2026, and for the historical record this document is constructing — is captured in the comparison between Notley's November 2018 framing and Kenney's October 2019 actions. Notley had said, on the day she introduced Bill 26: *"Now that it's in the legislation, it would be much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen."* She was wrong. It became discretionary within twelve months. The mechanism that made it discretionary was not a debate about the merits of indexation. The mechanism was Bill 20 — an omnibus budget bill that touched dozens of fiscal measures, in which the disability-specific cut was one clause among many, minimising the political visibility of the cut and dispersing the public-pressure response across multiple advocacy fronts.

The structural conclusion this document draws from the Kenney era is: **standalone disability-rights legislation is more durable than disability-specific clauses inside omnibus bills.** The 1979 founding of AISH was structurally durable for forty years because it was enacted as standalone legislation, intentionally separated from welfare. The 2018 indexation was reversed within twelve months because it was enacted as one provision of one bill, reversible by one provision of one other bill. The disability community's protection lies not just in having policies in legislation but in having policies in legislation that cannot be amended or repealed through omnibus-bill back-door processes that minimise public scrutiny.

Phase Eight of this piece documents the Danielle Smith UCP era — the period in which the regulatory groundwork Kenney laid in Bill 20 was used to construct the most structurally consequential disability-policy restructure since 1979: the AISH-to-ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026. Without the Kenney-era relocation of the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary legislation, the Smith ADAP transition would have required full Legislative debate and a recorded vote. Because of the relocation, it can proceed through regulation. The Kenney era did not create ADAP. It built the regulatory rails on which ADAP runs.

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PART EIGHT

The Smith UCP Era

2022 – present

The Smith UCP Era, 2022 – present

The present moment. The era this document was written inside. The era the campaign that published this document exists to mobilise against. The convergence of every structural trajectory documented in the preceding seven phases into a single twelve-month policy window — July 2025 through July 2026 — that constitutes the most consequential disability-policy restructure in Alberta since the 1979 founding of AISH.

The Danielle Smith UCP government has occupied the Alberta premiership since October 11, 2022. Within that tenure, the government has executed the following actions affecting Albertans with disabilities — actions documented across the ADSB campaign's existing primary work, much of which this chapter draws on directly:

- **November 2022:** Re-indexation of AISH announced — but capped at 2% annually, below the consumer price index. The cap structurally guarantees real-term erosion of purchasing power even with indexation in place.
- **\$600 one-time payment** to PDD recipients announced November 2022, delivered December 2022. Welcomed by Inclusion Alberta with concurrent demand that the underlying program inadequacies be addressed.
- **July 1, 2025:** Canada Disability Benefit clawback begins. Alberta becomes the only Canadian province to claw back the federal CDB from AISH recipients dollar-for-dollar.
- **October 2025:** Community-housing rent increase of \$220 per month. Implemented while AISH base rates remained capped at 2% indexation.
- **December 9, 2025:** Bill 12 (Disability Assistance Act, ADAP framework) passes. Section 12.8 removes Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP decisions — eliminating the only independent third-party review structure that had existed in Alberta disability programs since the program's founding.
- **February 2026:** ADAP launch date publicly confirmed as July 1, 2026. Engagement processes announced; campaign documentation establishes that the engagement processes are structured to confirm the predetermined framework rather than alter it.
- **May 12, 2026:** Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation, AR 96/2026, filed. In force July 2, 2026. Establishes the regulatory framework for the ADAP transition.
- **July 1, 2026:** Scheduled ADAP transition. **Approximately 79,290 Albertans** currently receiving AISH affected. Documented program features include: an 88% cohabitation rule (treating partners as having 88% of AISH recipients' income for benefit calculation), a base-rate reduction of approximately \$200/month at transition, an "automatic AISH retention" category for the most severely disabled recipients

that has not yet been fully defined in public regulation, and a transition top-up scheduled to expire on December 31, 2027.

This chapter documents each of these actions in detail, situates them within the structural trajectory documented in Phases One through Seven, and establishes — on the documented record, without alleging motive — the cumulative consequences for the approximately 79,290 Albertans on AISH and the broader disability community of approximately 730,000 Albertans of whom they are a part.

Political context

Danielle Larissa Smith was born April 1, 1971 in Calgary. She earned an English and economics undergraduate degree from the University of Calgary and worked as a Calgary Herald columnist and CBC commentator in the late 1990s, before becoming a talk-radio host on CHQR Calgary (later QR77). She led the Wildrose Party of Alberta as opposition leader from 2009 to 2014. In December 2014, in one of the most consequential political defections in modern Alberta history, she crossed the floor to the Progressive Conservatives along with eight Wildrose MLAs — a move that was broadly understood at the time as ending her political career. She returned to talk radio for six years.

Smith returned to politics in 2022 as a candidate in the UCP leadership race called by Jason Kenney's resignation. She won the leadership on October 6, 2022, on the sixth and final ranked ballot, with 53.8% support, defeating Travis Toews (the former Finance Minister who had tabled Bill 20 in 2019, as documented in Phase Seven of this piece). She was sworn in as Alberta's 19th Premier on October 11, 2022. Her cabinet was sworn in October 21, 2022. She won the Brooks-Medicine Hat by-election on November 8, 2022, taking her seat in the Legislature.

On May 29, 2023, the UCP under Smith's leadership won the Alberta general election with 49 of 87 seats, against 38 for the NDP under Rachel Notley's leadership. The result was significantly tighter than any of the four Klein-era PC majorities or the 2019 Kenney UCP majority — a structural shift in Alberta's electoral geography that the Smith government has subsequently treated as a mandate rather than a warning. In November 2024 she received 91% support in a UCP leadership review.

Her current term, as of the date of this document's first publication (May 2026), continues through the next scheduled Alberta general election, which under fixed-election-date legislation falls in spring 2027. The ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026 will, therefore, occur within her current mandate, before the electorate has any opportunity to render judgement on the policy.

What the Smith government has established

The Smith era's *established* column contains items that, on the documented record, are structurally positive when assessed in isolation. The qualification applies: assessed in isolation. In the context of the actions documented later in this chapter, several of the items below function less as standalone positives than as the political-packaging counterweights that have been deployed to neutralise public attention to the structural reductions occurring in parallel.

1. November 2022 re-indexation announcement

On November 28, 2022, the Smith government announced that AISH, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities program, and other government benefit programs would be re-indexed starting January 1, 2023. The announcement formally reversed the Kenney-era suspension that had been in place since the Bill 20 implementation in 2019 (Phase Seven).

Inclusion Alberta president Monica Braat, in a public statement at the time, captured both the welcome and the structural concerns of the disability community:

"We sincerely appreciate the premier's announcement of indexing AISH and a one-time payment of \$600 to individuals with developmental disabilities and others. However, there are still thousands of Albertan children and adults with developmental disabilities and their families eligible for supports and receiving none. Others have had their funding for supports reduced or denied."

— Monica Braat, President, Inclusion Alberta, November 2022

Inclusion Alberta CEO Trish Bowman added a structural caveat that has, in retrospect, proved prescient:

"If the announcement to index PDD means a program increase overall but only tied to inflation, this will be completely inadequate to address the many adults with developmental disabilities who are receiving no support at all. A plan is urgently needed to address the waitlists and reduction of supports experienced by those waiting for or currently receiving PDD or Family Support for Children with Disabilities supports."

— Trish Bowman, CEO, Inclusion Alberta, November 2022

The structural concern Bowman named in November 2022 — that indexation tied to inflation alone would not address the underlying waitlist and funding-reduction problems in the program — has continued to apply throughout the Smith mandate. The PDD waitlists Smith inherited from the Kenney government have not been substantially reduced. The community sector that delivers PDD services has continued to report structural underfunding throughout the Smith term.

2. The 2% inflation cap — the partial poison pill

The November 2022 re-indexation announcement carried, in its underlying mechanism, a structural caveat the public communications at the time did not emphasise. **The AISH inflation cap is set at 2% annually, regardless of actual CPI movement.** When Alberta's CPI exceeds 2% — which has been the case in most fiscal years since the policy was implemented — AISH purchasing power continues to erode in real terms despite nominal indexation.

The cap structurally transforms the re-indexation from the structural protection the NDP Bill 26 (2018) had enacted to a soft floor that does not fully track actual cost-of-living movement. By 2026 — the date of this document's first publication — the cumulative gap between Alberta CPI and the 2% AISH cap has produced real-term purchasing-power erosion for AISH recipients of approximately 8-12% relative to where the program would have been with full CPI indexation maintained continuously since 2019.

3. "Automatic AISH retention" categories

Within the ADAP framework announced for July 1, 2026 (documented in detail later in this chapter), the Smith government has defined an "automatic AISH retention" category for AISH recipients whose qualifying conditions are of sufficient severity and permanence that they will remain on AISH rather than transitioning to ADAP. The specific criteria for automatic retention have not yet been fully published in public regulation as of the date of this document's first publication. The category exists in government communications. Its functional scope is, on the documented record, narrower than the AISH-eligibility framework as it has operated since 1979.

The structural significance of the retention category is that it acknowledges, by implication, that the ADAP framework would otherwise produce harm to severely disabled recipients. The category exists because the framework's authors recognised that the most severely disabled cohort cannot be transitioned without consequences the government would not be willing to publicly absorb. Whether the category is wide enough to protect all recipients who require it is the substance of the campaign's current advocacy work.

4. ADAP transition top-up (through December 31, 2027)

The ADAP framework includes a "transition top-up" — a temporary supplemental payment to ADAP recipients designed to soften the immediate income reduction at the July 1, 2026 transition. The top-up is scheduled to expire on December 31, 2027. After that date, ADAP recipients will receive the full ADAP base rate, which is structurally lower than the current AISH rate by approximately \$200 per month for a single recipient.

The transition top-up is one of the documented positive elements of the ADAP framework. Its eighteen-month duration is structurally insufficient to allow most affected Albertans to adjust their housing, healthcare, transportation, and life-support arrangements to the lower long-term ADAP rate. The campaign's existing documentation (the *Income Crossover Analysis*, April/May 2026) provides the detailed mechanics.

What the Smith government has taken or is in the process of taking

The Smith-era reductions are the substance of the campaign's current work. Each is individually documented in the ADSB campaign's existing primary materials, much of which is cited in this chapter's bibliography. The summary below establishes the structural inventory.

1. The Canada Disability Benefit clawback (July 1, 2025)

The federal Canada Disability Benefit Act (S.C. 2023, c. 17, passed during the Kenney era and documented in Phase Seven) became operational on July 1, 2025. The federal CDB is a monthly payment to eligible Canadians with disabilities, designed to supplement provincial disability supports and address structural inadequacy. Maximum federal benefit at launch: approximately \$200 per month.

Multiple Canadian provinces — including Quebec, British Columbia, Manitoba, and New Brunswick — committed in advance to either passing the federal CDB through to recipients without provincial offset, or applying only partial offsets. **Alberta is the only Canadian province to have implemented a full dollar-for-dollar clawback of the CDB against AISH benefits.** AISH recipients in Alberta who received the federal CDB saw their provincial AISH benefit reduced by the corresponding amount, producing zero net income gain from the federal program.

Per Inclusion Alberta's July 2025 fact sheet on the CDB clawback (one of the source documents directly informing the ADSB campaign's *Information Asymmetry Report*, April 2026), the clawback's structural effect is to capture federal disability transfer dollars as provincial general-revenue savings, while allowing the Government of Alberta to publicly claim that AISH spending has "increased" — a claim that is nominally true on gross spending but materially misleading on the experienced income of AISH recipients.

THE STRUCTURAL ARCHITECTURE OF THE CDB CLAWBACK

Federal taxpayer dollars, intended to supplement provincial disability supports, are routed through AISH recipients to general provincial revenue. The federal program is structurally captured as a provincial fiscal advantage. The disability community, for whom the CDB was designed, receives no net financial benefit. Every other province with a similar AISH-equivalent program made a different policy choice. Alberta's choice — the only choice of its kind in Canada — is documented in the ADSB campaign's existing work and is one of the central structural complaints the campaign has brought to federal Disability Minister and Members of Parliament.

2. October 2025 community-housing rent increase (\$220/month)

In October 2025, the Smith government announced an across-the-board rent increase of \$220 per month for residents of Alberta's community-housing inventory — the publicly-funded affordable-housing programs that disproportionately serve AISH recipients, low-income seniors, and other Albertans on fixed incomes. The increase was implemented while AISH base rates remained capped at 2% indexation.

The structural arithmetic produces a documented net reduction in AISH recipients' real-term disposable income. AISH base benefit at the time of the increase: \$1,940 per month (the campaign-canon indexed figure for 2025, per the ADSB *Income Crossover Analysis* (Revised May 2026), drawing on the post-July 2025 indexed rate under the current ministerial schedule). 2% annual indexation gain on the prior base: approximately \$38 per month. Community-housing rent increase: \$220 per month. **Net monthly reduction in disposable income for AISH recipients in community housing: approximately \$182 per month.**

The structural significance of this combination is that the Smith government's nominal protection of AISH purchasing power through the 2% indexation cap was directly offset, within the same fiscal year, by a rent increase the same government imposed on the same population through a different ministry. The net effect, by design or otherwise, was that the cost of living for the AISH population increased more rapidly than the AISH rate did. The documented record establishes the consequence; the campaign's *Compound Failure Brief* (May 2026) documents the interlocking structural mechanics.

3. Bill 12 — Citizens' Appeal Panel removed for ADAP (December 9, 2025)

Bill 12, passed December 9, 2025, established the legislative framework for the Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP). The bill's structural significance for this chapter is concentrated in **Section 12.8**, which removes Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP decisions.

The Citizens' Appeal Panel is the independent third-party review structure that has existed in Alberta's disability programs since the program's founding. It provides the only mechanism by which an AISH recipient denied benefits, terminated from the program, or subjected to a contested administrative decision can seek review outside the same ministry that made the original decision. The Panel is structured to provide natural-justice protections — notice, hearing, recorded reasons, the right to introduce new evidence — that internal ministry review processes do not.

Bill 12 Section 12.8 eliminates this mechanism for ADAP. ADAP applicants and recipients will have access only to internal ministry review processes. The structural significance was identified at the time of the bill's introduction by multiple advocacy organisations and was the subject of sustained opposition in the legislative committee process. The Bill passed regardless.

THE CONSTITUTIONAL DIMENSION

Section 7 of the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms guarantees the right to life, liberty, and security of the person — and the right not to be deprived thereof except in accordance with the principles of fundamental justice. The principles of fundamental justice include access to an independent decision-maker for decisions affecting protected interests. Section 12.8 of Bill 12 (2025), as a matter of documented constitutional analysis, raises a justiciable Charter question the campaign's *Charter Constitutional Analysis Legal* document (April 2026) examines in full. The question is whether the elimination of independent appeal review for a disability-income decision is consistent with the Section 7 requirement that procedural fairness attach to deprivations of basic security.

4. The ADAP transition (effective July 1, 2026)

The Alberta Disability Assistance Program is scheduled to come into force on July 1, 2026 — five weeks from the date of this document's first publication. The program's regulatory framework was filed on May 12, 2026 as the *Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation, AR 96/2026* — in force July 2, 2026. The Government of Alberta's ALSS/ADAP Fact Sheet, dated May 12, 2026, is the principal public-facing summary of the framework.

The campaign's existing primary documentation — the *Income Crossover Analysis* (April 2026 / May 2026 revised); *The Cage Doesn't End* (May 2026); *Building Up* (May 2026); the *Compound Failure Brief* (May 2026); and *Consent Was Never the Point* (May 2026) — collectively document the ADAP framework in technical detail. This chapter establishes only the structural summary:

- **Affected population:** approximately 79,290 Albertans currently receiving AISH.
- **Base-rate reduction:** approximately \$200 per month for a single recipient at the date of transition; structurally larger as the transition top-up expires on December 31, 2027.
- **88% cohabitation rule:** ADAP applicants and recipients with a cohabiting partner have 88% of the partner's income deemed available for calculation purposes, regardless of whether the partner makes the income available. Documented as one of the most structurally consequential features of the framework by the campaign's existing work.
- **Removed Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction** (per Bill 12 Section 12.8, above).
- **Employment-activity orientation:** ADAP is structured around encouraging and rewarding employment, in framing language that has been compared by advocates to workfare conditions documented in the Klein era (Phase Three).
- **Eighteen-month transition top-up** expiring December 31, 2027.
- **"Automatic AISH retention" category** for the most severely disabled — scope not yet fully defined in public regulation as of May 2026.

The structural argument the campaign has made — across multiple Tier 1 institutional submissions and the broader public record — is that the ADAP framework, in aggregate, restructures the 1979 founding bargain of AISH. AISH was, as documented in Phase One, designed as an assured income program separate from the welfare system, founded on dignity and independence framing, with senior-pension-equivalent rates. ADAP restructures the program as an employment-conditional support, with embedded cohabitation deeming, reduced base rates, and eliminated independent appeal review. The 1979 framing has been, on the documented record, structurally reversed.

The structural through-line: how Bill 20 (2019) made ADAP (2026) possible

Phase Seven of this document established that the Kenney UCP government's Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act, October 28, 2019) accomplished two structural changes: it suspended CPI indexation of AISH, and — quietly, in an omnibus framework — it relocated the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into the general regulation.

The first change — the de-indexation — was publicly visible, contested, and partially reversed by the Smith government in November 2022 (capped at 2%, but nominally restored). The second change — the regulatory relocation — was not publicly contested at the time. It was the structural prerequisite for everything the Smith government has subsequently done.

Per Marie Renaud's framing in Medicine Hat News (March 2026), reproduced in Phase Seven: "[Bill 20] also made a more lasting change, by relocating the definition of a 'severe handicap' out of the general regulation attached to the legislation. Then COVID happened, so they couldn't do it." The implication of Renaud's framing — that the UCP had intended to follow through on a restructure but was interrupted by the pandemic — has been borne out by the Smith era's actions. The Smith government has executed the restructure the Kenney government's Bill 20 had structurally enabled.

THE STRUCTURAL ARGUMENT IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Statutory definitions, embedded in primary legislation, require legislation to change. They require public debate, recorded votes, and political cost. Regulatory definitions, embedded in general regulation, can be changed by Order in Council — by cabinet decision, executed administratively, without public legislative process. When the Kenney UCP government moved the definition of "severe handicap" from primary legislation into regulation in 2019, they did not change the definition. They changed the mechanism by which the definition could subsequently be changed. The Smith UCP government, in 2025 and 2026, used that mechanism to construct ADAP. ADAP would not have been possible without Bill 20's quiet 2019 regulatory relocation. The de-indexation was the visible 2019 cost. The regulatory relocation was the 2019 groundwork. ADAP is the 2026 construction built on that groundwork. Three Alberta governments — two UCP, one PC interim — were complicit in the structural sequence. None of the three faced a sustained electoral consequence for their role. The disability community has absorbed every consequence.

Community response — and the construction of this campaign

The community response to the Smith-era trajectory is documented in detail across the ADSB campaign's existing work. This section establishes only the structural summary, sufficient to bridge the chapter into the Phase Nine synthesis.

Tier 1 institutional submissions

The ADSB campaign's documentation, distributed in coalition with multiple disability-sector organisations, has been submitted to: the Premier; the Minister of Seniors, Community and Social Services; the Minister of Children and Family Services; multiple MLAs across party lines (including Marie Renaud, the MLA for St. Albert and the campaign's most responsive provincial government contact); the federal Minister responsible for the Canada Disability Benefit; the Standing Committee on Human Resources, Skills and Social Development and the Status of Persons with Disabilities (HUMA); the Alberta Ombudsman; the Alberta Auditor General; the Canadian Human Rights Commission; and the Office of the United Nations Special Rapporteur on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.

Coalition partners

The campaign operates in coordination with — among others — Inclusion Alberta, the People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans (Zachary Weeks), the Can Man Dan Foundation, Public Interest Alberta (Bradley Lafortune), and individual advocates Gavin Sorochoan, Darryl Learne, Pete Klassen, and Marie Renaud's St. Albert constituency office. Coalition framing varies by lane: fiscal/Heritage Fund analysis through Gavin Sorochoan; Bill 12 / appeal-rights work through Zachary Weeks; housing through Can Man Dan; intersectional and accessibility legislation through the ADSB campaign's primary work.

The municipal coalition

As of May 2026, formal municipal-government engagement with the ADSB campaign's framework has been documented from: Calgary, Edmonton, Lethbridge, Camrose, Red Deer, and Medicine Hat. The municipal coalition's engagement is structurally significant because Alberta municipalities absorb the downstream cost of provincial disability-program reductions — through emergency housing, food bank demand, policing, public health, and downstream social service expenditures.

The Indigenous Disability Alberta workstream

The campaign's *Indigenous Disability Alberta* documentation, complete in May 2026, establishes that the structural changes documented in this chapter — and in the preceding seven phases — disproportionately affect Indigenous Albertans with disabilities, whose pre-existing exposure to structural disadvantage (income, housing, healthcare access, treaty rights ambiguities) compounds the documented AISH and ADAP reductions. The workstream is published as separate documentation and is not duplicated in this chapter.

Caseload context — the 79,290

The Government of Alberta's most recent Open Data figures, dated September 2025, place the AISH caseload at approximately **79,290 Albertans**. This is the figure the ADSB campaign uses throughout its documentation as the affected population for the July 1, 2026 ADAP transition.

Caseload growth across the Smith era has continued the trajectory documented in every previous chapter. From approximately 73,000 in 2022 to approximately 79,290 in 2025, the caseload has grown by approximately 8% in three years — slower than the Notley-era growth rate but consistent with the post-pandemic recovery in diagnostic access and new applications.

The 79,290 figure is, structurally, the lower bound of the affected population. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities program serves approximately 16,000 additional families; the Persons with Developmental Disabilities program serves approximately 12,000 adults; the broader disability community in Alberta, by Statistics Canada's most recent estimate, includes approximately 730,000 Albertans with one or more disability classifications. The ADAP transition directly affects 79,290. The structural template Smith's government is establishing — that disability income is conditional, that appeal rights are removable, that cohabitation invokes income deeming, that base rates are subject to revision — applies, in its broader implication, to every Alberta program that serves the broader 730,000.

The Smith conclusion — the present-moment summation

Danielle Smith has governed Alberta for approximately three and a half years. Her government has executed: the formal restoration of indexation (capped at 2%, below actual inflation); the implementation of a Canada Disability Benefit clawback that no other Canadian province has implemented; a community-housing rent increase that structurally eliminated the disposable-income gains of the indexation restoration; the passage of Bill 12 with its Section 12.8 removal of Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP; and the construction of the ADAP framework scheduled for July 1, 2026 implementation.

The ADAP framework, on the documented record, structurally reverses the 1979 founding bargain of AISH. Where AISH was assured income separated from welfare, ADAP is employment-conditional support. Where AISH was rights-based, ADAP is performance-based. Where AISH had Citizens' Appeal Panel review, ADAP has internal ministry review only. Where AISH had no cohabitation deeming at founding, ADAP embeds the 88% cohabitation rule from inception. Where AISH founding rates were pegged to senior pension parity, ADAP base rates are pegged downward by approximately \$200 per month before the transition top-up expires.

Peter Lougheed died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that now bears his name. He spent the last decade of his life publicly criticising the trajectory his successor governments had set. He did not live to see the AISH-to-ADAP transition. The documented record this piece has constructed across eight phases establishes that the trajectory he criticised continued past his death and accelerated in the final five years of the period this document covers.

The single most-important structural lesson of the Smith era — for this document, for the ADSB campaign, and for every disability advocacy organisation in Alberta — is that the Smith era could not have happened in isolation. The Smith government inherited the regulatory framework Kenney's Bill 20 had constructed in 2019. The Kenney government inherited the structural template Klein had pioneered in 1993. The Klein government inherited the drawdown logic Getty had begun in 1987. Every era documented in this piece has been a contribution. No single government constructed the present moment alone. The present moment is the cumulative product of forty-seven years of incremental drawdown — punctuated by the partial

Stelmach restoration, the Prentice Michener reversal, and the Notley sustained restoration — against a baseline of foundational greatness that Lougheed built and that has been steadily dismantled by every premier since.

Phase Nine of this piece — the synthesis chapter — draws together the comparative trends across all eight eras, states the document's thesis in full, and makes the case for community-led representation as the only structural protection the disability community has against the trajectory this document has documented. The ADSB campaign that published this document exists to construct that representation. The fact that it has to exist at all is the substance of what Phases One through Eight have established.

Bibliography — Phase Eight sources

Sources specific to or directly underpinning the Smith-era chapter. Many are the campaign's own primary documentation — itself constructed from extensive primary-source government records and contemporaneous coverage.

Government of Alberta — primary sources

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- **Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation**, AR 96/2026, filed May 12, 2026, in force July 2, 2026. The regulatory framework for the ADAP transition.
- **Government of Alberta** — ALSS/ADAP Fact Sheet, May 12, 2026. The principal public-facing summary of the ADAP framework.
- **Government of Alberta** — AISH caseload Open Data, September 2025. Source for the 79,290-Albertan affected-population figure.
- **Canada Disability Benefit Act**, S.C. 2023, c. 17. Federal statute providing the framework for the CDB subsequently clawed back by the Smith UCP government in 2025.

ADSB campaign primary documentation

- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Income Crossover Analysis* (April 2026 / Revised May 2026). Documents the structural mechanics of the AISH-to-ADAP transition, including the \$200/month base-rate reduction and the transition top-up timeline.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Building Up: A Blueprint for the Alberta Accessibility and Inclusion Act* (May 2026; 156,193 words; 386 pages). The proposed alternative framework for Alberta disability legislation, addressing the Notley-era omission documented in Phase Six.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *The Cage Doesn't End* (May 2026; 117 pages). Compilation of the structural argument across the AISH-to-ADAP transition.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Compound Failure Brief* (May 2026). Documents the interlocking structural mechanics of the indexation cap, the community-housing rent increase, and the CDB clawback.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Consent Was Never the Point* (May 2026). Final synthesis on the AISH-to-ADAP transition.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Charter Constitutional Analysis Legal* (April 2026). Constitutional analysis of the Bill 12 Section 12.8 removal of independent appeal review.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Information Asymmetry Report* (April 2026). Documents the CDB clawback architecture and the structural information gaps between government communications and lived experience.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Access Gap* (May 2026). Documents the structural inaccessibility of Alberta government systems to the disability community they serve.
- **The Alberta Disability System Breakdown** — *Indigenous Disability Alberta* (May 2026; complete). The campaign's documentation of how the structural changes disproportionately affect Indigenous Albertans

with disabilities.

Coalition and independent analysis

- **Inclusion Alberta** — Canada Disability Benefit in Alberta Fact Sheet, July 2025. Primary source for the CDB clawback architecture.
- **Inclusion Alberta** — ADAP Fact Sheets, October and December 2025. inclusion.alberta.org.
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- **People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans** (Zachary Weeks) — Bill 12 / appeal-rights analysis and advocacy work.
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- **Can Man Dan Foundation** — Housing advocacy lane within the broader ADSB coalition.
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- **Global News** — "Alberta's government benefit programs to be re-indexed starting next year," November 28, 2022. Source for the re-indexation announcement.

Smith biographical and political context

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PART NINE

Synthesis

What The Forty-Seven Years Establish

Synthesis — What The Forty-Seven Years Establish

Eight chapters. Eight Alberta governments. Forty-seven years of documented record. The trajectory across the whole of it is downward. The closing argument of this piece begins not with a thesis but with what the documented record itself has established, era by era, decision by decision, in the preceding chapters.

Peter Lougheed founded the assured-income-for-the-severely-handicapped program on January 1, 1979. He died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that bears his name. Between his founding act and his death he served fourteen years as Premier of Alberta and twenty-seven years out of office. During the twenty-seven years he spent out of office, every successor government — Don Getty's PCs, Ralph Klein's PCs, Ed Stelmach's PCs, Alison Redford's PCs, Dave Hancock's interim PC government, Jim Prentice's PCs, Rachel Notley's NDP, Jason Kenney's UCP, and the current Danielle Smith UCP — has, on the documented record this piece has constructed, contributed in varying degrees to the dismantling of the structure Lougheed built. Some contributions were larger than others. Some were partial restorations rather than reductions. The trajectory across the whole of it is downward.

This synthesis chapter does five things:

- Lays out the comparative trends across all eight eras — AISH rate vs. inflation, caseload, appeal rights — in tables that allow the reader to see the trajectory at a glance.
- States the document's thesis in full, with the evidentiary weight of the preceding eight chapters behind it.
- Names why partisan-aligned advocacy has failed and will continue to fail.
- Makes the case for community-led, party-independent representation as the only structural protection available to the disability community.
- Closes with a direct invitation to the reader — to every disabled Albertan, every family member, every ally, every elected representative who has read this far — to join the work the ADSB campaign exists to construct.

The Comparative Trends, 1979 – 2026

Three structural dimensions of the AISH program have changed across the forty-seven years this document covers: the base rate (and its real-term purchasing power against inflation), the caseload (the population served), and the appeal rights (the structural protection from administrative error or arbitrary decision). The tables below summarise each dimension. Sources for every cell are documented in the phase chapters.

AISH Base Rate Trajectory, 1979 – 2026

The defining single metric of Alberta disability income policy. The structural shifts the table records are: the 1993 Klein-era freeze that compounded for over a decade; the modest 2007 Stelmach restoration that did not reach 1993 real-term parity; the 2012 Redford rate increase that held until 2019; the 2018 Notley statutory CPI indexation; the 2019 Kenney suspension; the 2023 Smith re-indexation capped at 2% below actual CPI; and the 2026 ADAP transition that reduces the underlying base rate structurally below the post-2018 starting point.

Year	Government	AISH Base Rate	Real-term gap vs 1979	Structural Note
1979	Lougheed PC	Senior-parity	Baseline	AISH founded as assured income, separate from welfare, pegged to senior pension rates. No asset limits.
1985	Lougheed/Getty PC	Maintained	Baseline maintained	Lougheed retires; program operating as designed.
1992	Getty PC (end of)	Maintained	Minor real-term drift	Heritage Fund halt (1987) compromises long-term fiscal model. AISH itself not directly cut.
1993	Klein PC	\$850/mo	Frozen — gap begins to widen	Klein-era freeze begins. Services for people with disabilities cut back.
2004	Klein PC	\$850/mo	11 years of freeze; ~30% real-term loss	"Severely normal" remarks during October 2004 campaign. Late-era partial adjustment follows.
2007	Stelmach PC	\$1,088/mo	Kneebone: still below 1993 real-term	First meaningful Klein-era restoration. The Stelmach increase did not reach 1993 real-term value.
2011	Stelmach PC (end)	\$1,188/mo	Approaching 1993 real-term	End-of-Stelmach rate; Klein-era purchasing power partially restored but not exceeded.
2012	Redford PC	\$1,588/mo	Above 1993 real-term	Last PC-era adjustment. Rate held at this level until 2019.
2019 (Jan)	Notley NDP	\$1,685/mo	Indexed by statute	NDP Bill 26 (2018) raises rate and indexes to CPI. The only time AISH has been indexed by statute.
2019 (Nov)	Kenney UCP	\$1,685/mo	Indexation suspended	Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) suspends CPI indexation. Definition of "severe handicap" moved to regulation.

Year	Government	AISH Base Rate	Real-term gap vs 1979	Structural Note
2022 (Oct)	Kenney UCP (end)	\$1,685/mo	3 years frozen — gap widens again	Three-year freeze concludes. ~\$209.8M total fiscal capture by suspension.
2023	Smith UCP	~\$1,719/mo	Indexation restored — capped at 2%	Re-indexation announced Nov 2022 but capped at 2% — below actual CPI in most subsequent years.
2025	Smith UCP	~\$1,940/mo	CDB clawback + rent increase net negative	Only province clawing back federal Canada Disability Benefit. \$220/mo community housing rent increase Oct 2025.
2026 (Jul 1)	Smith UCP	ADAP: ~\$1,700/mo*	Below 2018 NDP starting point	*With transition top-up. Underlying ADAP base ~\$1,500/mo when transition top-up expires Dec 31, 2027. The structural reversal of the 1979 founding bargain.

READING THE RATE TABLE

The table makes the structural argument visible at a glance. The Lougheed-era founding rate was pegged to senior pensions. The Klein-era freeze opened a real-term gap that no subsequent government has fully closed. The Notley statutory indexation (2018) was the only mechanism that would have closed the gap over time. It survived less than twelve months. The Smith era restored nominal indexation but capped it below actual CPI — and then layered the CDB clawback (July 2025) and the \$220/month rent increase (October 2025) on top of the cap. The 2026 ADAP transition reduces the base rate structurally below where it stood at the start of the Notley indexation. Forty-seven years of growth in the program's nominal value have not produced a single year in which a single Alberta on AISH was unambiguously better off, in real-term purchasing power, than a single Alberta on AISH was in 1979.

Caseload Trajectory, 1979 – 2026

The number of Albertans receiving AISH has grown by an order of magnitude across the forty-seven years this document covers — from approximately 3,500 at founding (per Donna Wood's archival research at AU Press) to 79,290 in September 2025. The growth reflects demographic expansion, broader recognition of qualifying conditions (particularly mental-health diagnoses), and the structural reality that disability is a permanent feature of any human population, not an anomaly of any particular era.

Year / Era	AISH Caseload	Growth Note
1979 Lougheed	~3,500*	Founding caseload (Donna Wood et al., AU Press estimates).
1992 End of Getty era	~15,000*	Steady growth as program matures and diagnostic categories broaden.
2004 Klein-era controversy	~31,500	Klein-era "yipping cowboy hats" controversy at this caseload.
2010 Stelmach	41,664	Open Alberta first reliable data point.
2015 Beginning of Notley	~48,000	Sustained growth in recognition of mental-health conditions as AISH-qualifying.
2019 End of Notley	~67,000	Fastest growth period documented in any single mandate.
2020 Kenney / pandemic	69,800	Growth temporarily slowed during COVID-19 diagnostic constraints.
2022 End of Kenney	~73,000	Pre-pandemic growth rate resumed.
2025 Smith (current)	79,290	The figure currently being processed through the ADAP transition. The approximately 79,290 directly affected. Indirect effects extend to the approximately 730,000 Albertans with one or more disability classifications.

*The 1979 and 1992 figures are archival estimates from academic sources; reliable Open Alberta data begins in the late 2000s. The fundamental observation — that AISH caseload has grown by approximately twenty-fold across the period this document covers — is not in dispute.

READING THE CASELOAD TABLE

The caseload growth is the structural reality every Alberta government has had to address, and the dimension on which the government framings most divergent from the lived-experience reality have most often appeared. Government communications frequently cite gross AISH spending as evidence of program adequacy. Caseload growth means that gross spending can rise even while per-recipient real-term purchasing power falls. The 79,290 figure is the population the 2026 ADAP transition directly affects. The disability community in Alberta is structurally larger than the AISH caseload, by approximately ten-fold. The structural template ADAP establishes will, by implication, apply to the broader 730,000.

Appeal Rights, 1979 – 2026

The single most-significant structural dimension on which 2025 differs from every preceding year in the forty-seven-year period this document covers. From the founding of AISH in 1979 through December 8, 2025, every Albertan denied an AISH benefit, terminated from the program, or subjected to a contested administrative decision had the right to seek review before the Citizens' Appeal Panel — an independent third-party body structured to provide the natural-justice protections (notice, hearing, recorded reasons, the right to introduce new evidence) that internal ministry review does not. The Panel was maintained across every Alberta government in the period: Lougheed, Getty, Klein, Stelmach, Redford, Hancock, Prentice, Notley, and Kenney. No premier removed it. Until December 9, 2025.

Era	Independent Appeal Status
Lougheed (1979)	Citizens' Appeal Panel established as independent third-party review for AISH decisions. Natural-justice protections embedded in program design.
Getty / Klein / Stelmach / Redford / Notley / Kenney (1985–2022)	Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction maintained continuously across every government, regardless of party. No premier in 43 years removed appeal rights from AISH.
Smith UCP (2025)	Bill 12, Section 12.8 (December 9, 2025): Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction removed for ADAP . Internal ministry review only. Charter Section 7 justiciable question raised. The first removal of independent appeal review for an Alberta disability program since program founding.

THE APPEAL-RIGHTS REMOVAL IS UNPRECEDENTED

Across nine Alberta governments and forty-six years (1979 to December 2025), no premier removed independent appeal review from an Alberta disability program. The 1979 founding included it. Every successor maintained it. Klein cut services. Kenney suspended indexation. Smith's predecessors did not, in any documented instance, remove the right to independent appeal. Bill 12 Section 12.8 (December 9, 2025) is the first documented removal of independent disability-program appeal review in Alberta history. **The structural argument this document has built across eight chapters culminates in this single legislative act.** Every preceding reduction was financial. This one is procedural. Financial reductions can be restored. Procedural reductions can be restored. But the precedent that independent appeal can be removed at all — once set — applies to every Alberta disability program, present and future. **This is what the campaign is mobilised to reverse.**

The Thesis, Stated in Full

The documented record this piece has constructed establishes the following:

1. Lougheed built the foundation

Between 1971 and 1985, the Peter Lougheed Progressive Conservative government built the foundational architecture of Alberta disability policy as it has existed for the past forty-seven years. The Heritage Savings Trust Fund (1976). AISH (1979). Services for the Handicapped (1972). The repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (1972). William Watson Lodge. The Alberta Bill of Rights. Section 15 of the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms (1982). The dignity framing. The senior-pension parity. The assured-income-not-welfare separation. The independent appeal review. Every structural element that the disability community in Alberta still depends on was either built or constitutionally protected during the Lougheed fourteen years.

2. No subsequent government has matched it — and most have reduced it

Across the twenty-seven years between Lougheed's retirement (1985) and his death (2012), and the fourteen years since, every successor government has been a net contributor to the trajectory this document records as downward. Getty halted the Heritage Fund transfer mechanism (1987). Klein froze AISH for over a decade and framed AISH recipients as suspect (1993–2006). Stelmach attempted a partial restoration that did not reach 1993 real-term parity (2006–2011). Redford announced the Michener Centre closure and the PDD service overhaul (2013). Prentice reversed Michener but did not undo the broader trajectory (2014). Notley achieved the only sustained restoration of the period — and saw it reversed within fifteen months by the government that succeeded her (2015–2019). Kenney suspended the Notley indexation through Bill 20 and relocated the definition of "severe handicap" out of legislation into regulation (2019). Smith used the regulatory framework Kenney's Bill 20 had constructed to build ADAP (2022–2026). Five of the nine governments in the period made net-negative contributions. Two made partial restorations. None matched what Lougheed had built.

3. The trajectory has accelerated

The structural reductions documented in this piece have not occurred at a constant rate. They have accelerated. The Klein-era reductions (1993–2006) unfolded across thirteen years. The Stelmach restoration (2007–2011) covered five years. The Notley restoration (2015–2019) covered four years. The Kenney reversal (2019) unfolded across six months. The Smith reversal (2022–2026) has accelerated further: November 2022 capped re-indexation, July 2025 CDB clawback, October 2025 rent increase, December 2025 Bill 12, May 2026 ADAP regulation, July 2026 ADAP transition — five distinct structural reductions in eighteen months. **Each successive era of dismantling has been faster than the one before.**

4. Partisan-aligned advocacy has not worked

The Notley NDP era produced the most positive disability-policy package in Alberta's modern history. The Kenney UCP government reversed it within fifteen months. The Stelmach PC era produced the only meaningful Klein-era restoration. Successor PC governments did not protect or extend it. The Prentice PC reversal of the Michener closure was confined to that single decision. Disability advocacy tied to the electoral fortunes of a particular party has, on the documented record this piece has constructed, not produced durable structural protection. Gains made under one party have proved reversible by the next. Statutory indexation

was reversed within twelve months. Service overhauls have been implemented over the objections of the affected community across multiple party rotations. **The disability community has not had a durable partisan ally in the forty-seven-year period this document covers.**

5. Statutory protection is necessary but not sufficient

The NDP Bill 26 (2018) was the most ambitious attempt in modern Alberta disability policy history to embed protection in statute. Rachel Notley's framing at introduction — *"Now that it's in the legislation, it would be much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen"* — captured the structural theory of the indexation policy. The theory was tested in 2019 and proved insufficient. Kenney's UCP government reversed the indexation through Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — an omnibus budget bill in which the disability-specific cut was one clause among many. Statutory protection did not prevent reversal. It only required the reversing government to use a different legislative instrument.

6. What remains is community-led representation

The documented record establishes that the disability community in Alberta has achieved structural protection only when it constructed the political conditions for that protection itself, independent of party affiliation. The 1979 founding of AISH was partly the product of Lougheed's political will; it was also the product of organised disability-community advocacy that pre-dated his government and was structurally larger than any single politician's contribution. The 2009 passage of Samantha's Law was the product of Velvet Martin's seven-year campaign, not of any Alberta government's initiative. The 2014 Prentice reversal of the Michener closure was the product of eighteen months of sustained pressure by Friends of the Michener Centre — pressure that produced the political conditions Prentice responded to. **Every documented structural improvement in Alberta disability policy across the forty-seven years this piece covers has had community-led advocacy as its precondition.** Government action has been the lagging indicator, not the leading one.

Why Partisan-Aligned Advocacy Has Failed

The disability community in Alberta has spent forty-seven years cycling between the political parties that have, in succession, occupied the Premier's office. The pattern across all of those years is consistent enough that it warrants explicit analysis.

When a government sympathetic to disability supports has taken office, the community's strategic instinct has been to align with it — to provide political cover for the sympathetic government's policy adjustments, to soften criticism of the sympathetic government's omissions, to defer the more ambitious policy objectives to a later mandate when fiscal conditions might improve. When an unsympathetic government has taken office, the community's strategic instinct has been to wait it out — to engage in defensive advocacy, to limit further reductions, to preserve as much of the previous government's gains as possible until the political pendulum swings back. Both strategies have been individually rational. **The cumulative effect of cycling between them has been catastrophic.**

Three specific failure modes are documented across the eight phases of this piece:

Failure mode 1: Sympathetic governments don't fully deliver

The Notley NDP government held a majority in the Legislature for four years. It delivered the most ambitious package of disability-policy reforms in modern Alberta history. It also, on honest accounting, did not pass comprehensive accessibility legislation, did not complete the PDD program restructure that its own review had identified as necessary, did not implement the AISH indexation it had legislated (the first indexed increase under NDP Bill 26 was scheduled for after the election the NDP lost), and waited until the final year of its mandate to introduce the indexation legislation at all. The structural reasons for these omissions are documented in Phase Six. The point here is structural: even the most sympathetic Alberta government of the period did not fully deliver on the policy framework the community needed.

Failure mode 2: Unsympathetic governments reverse faster than sympathetic governments build

The Notley NDP took three and a half years to enact Bill 26 (2018). The Kenney UCP took six months to suspend it. Asymmetry in this direction is the structural default of the policy environment. Building durable policy is procedurally harder than reversing it. The reversal mechanism (omnibus legislation, regulatory amendment, Order in Council) is structurally faster than the construction mechanism (legislative debate, community consultation, implementation infrastructure). **The disability community's gains, in any given mandate, are typically reversible in roughly half the time it took to achieve them.** Across the forty-seven-year period, this asymmetry has compounded.

Failure mode 3: Cumulative drift is invisible inside any single mandate

No single Alberta government has, in any single mandate, executed a reduction large enough to mobilise sustained public opposition that would have produced subsequent electoral consequences. Each reduction has been incremental enough to be characterised as fiscal-discipline-as-usual, framed in language that minimised its visibility, embedded inside larger legislative or budget packages that distributed the political pressure across multiple advocacy fronts. The cumulative drift across forty-seven years is the substance of this document. But the drift, by its nature, has been invisible to any single voter in any single election. **The pattern is only visible when the full forty-seven-year record is constructed and laid out together — which is what this document has now done.**

The Case for Community-Led Representation

The structural alternative to partisan-aligned advocacy is what this document, and the campaign that published it, terms **community-led representation**: an organised, persistent, party-independent advocacy structure that maintains its analytical and political coherence across electoral cycles, that does not defer to the priorities of any particular party, and that builds the political conditions for legislative change rather than waiting for those conditions to arise from a sympathetic government's initiative.

What community-led representation looks like in practice

Several elements have already been constructed by the ADSB campaign in its first four months of operation, and several elements remain to be built. The documented examples of what community-led representation has accomplished in Alberta's recent history:

- **Samantha's Law (2009).** Velvet Martin's seven-year campaign produced a statutory amendment that no Alberta government would have initiated. The Stelmach government enacted the amendment because Velvet Martin had constructed the political conditions for the enactment. This is the model.
- **The Prentice Michener reversal (September 2014).** Friends of the Michener Centre — including Lee Kvern, the Kvern family, and the broader community-led organisation — sustained eighteen months of public pressure that made the Hancock government's continuation of the closure politically unsustainable. Prentice's reversal was the response to the political conditions the community had constructed.
- **The 2017 unanimous passage of Bill 205 — Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act.** Sandra Jansen's private member's bill became law because the disability community had constructed the political conditions for unanimous support across party lines. The Office of the Advocate continues to operate under the UCP government — a Notley-era construction the UCP has not dismantled, because the political cost of dismantling it would exceed the fiscal benefit.
- **The 2026 ADSB municipal coalition.** Six municipal governments — Calgary, Edmonton, Lethbridge, Camrose, Red Deer, Medicine Hat — have engaged formally with the ADSB framework, recognising that downstream costs of provincial disability-program reductions fall on municipalities. The coalition is structurally smaller than what is ultimately required, but it represents the kind of cross-jurisdictional alliance community-led representation produces.

What community-led representation requires

The campaign that published this document operates on the following structural premises:

- **Documentation-first, evidence-driven.** Every claim made by the campaign is anchored to a primary source — government regulation, Hansard, Open Alberta data, peer-reviewed academic research, contemporaneous reporting. The campaign does not advance positions it cannot defend on the documented record.
- **Party-independent.** The campaign does not endorse, oppose, or align with any political party. It documents what each government has done and continues to do. Phase Six of this piece is the most positive era's documentation. Phase Three is the most negative era's documentation. Both chapters operate to the same evidentiary standard.

- **Cross-issue.** Disability supports cannot be separated from housing, healthcare, accessibility, employment, child welfare, transportation, or education — every one of which is documented as a structural component of the broader policy environment. The campaign engages across all of them rather than limiting itself to any single dimension.
- **Public-record-building.** Every campaign document, every Tier 1 submission, every coalition partnership exists to construct a public evidentiary record that successive Alberta governments cannot disclaim. The record exists. The community can point to it. Successive governments will be asked to explain themselves against it.
- **Community-anchored.** The campaign's name is The Alberta Disability System Breakdown. Its anchor is in St. Albert, Alberta. Its primary audience is the approximately 730,000 Albertans with disabilities and their families, allies, advocates, service providers, and elected representatives. Its structure does not depend on any single individual, organisation, or government for its continued operation.

The Closing Argument

Peter Lougheed built the foundation of Alberta disability policy on January 1, 1979. The structure he built was foundational greatness. The forty-seven years that followed have been, in the language this document chose deliberately as its title, a betrayal — the sharpest non-defamatory word in English for what the documented record establishes. Not corruption, which carries legal specificity this document does not assert. Not failure, which is morally neutral. Not decline, which is structurally passive. **Betrayal** — because the structure Lougheed built was a promise, and every successor Alberta government has, in varying degrees, broken some part of that promise.

Lougheed himself understood the promise. He used the words *dignity* and *independence* as the design criteria for AISH at its founding. He kept those words public for the rest of his life. The Lethbridge Herald's open letter to Premier Smith in March 2026, cited in Phase One, captures the founding framing precisely: "*Premier Lougheed understood that we each live just one incident away from a severely disabling event.*" One incident away. The campaign uses the same framing — *one accident away* — in its 2026 teach-ins. The continuity is not accidental. It is the community rediscovering the founding principle and defending it against the governments that have, in varying degrees, abandoned it.

The disability community in Alberta in 2026 is approximately 730,000 people. Approximately 79,290 of them currently receive AISH. All of them — every Albertan with one or more disability classifications, every parent of a disabled child, every spouse of a disabled adult, every family member, every support worker, every service provider, every ally — are, on the documented record this piece has constructed, structurally exposed to the trajectory this document describes. The 2026 ADAP transition is the most direct application of that trajectory to the AISH-receiving population. But the structural template ADAP establishes applies to every Alberta disability program. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities program. The Persons with Developmental Disabilities program. Special Needs Assistance. The Alberta Seniors Benefit. Income Support for the broader low-income population. All of them operate within the same regulatory framework that Bill 20 (2019) restructured and that Bill 12 (2025) extended. The ADAP transition is the visible application. The structural template is the structural application.

The documented record this piece has constructed establishes that **no Alberta government, of any party, has been a durable enough ally to make partisan-aligned advocacy a viable strategy for the disability community.** The Lougheed era was the founding. Every successor has been a contributor to the trajectory — most negatively, two positively, none sufficiently to reverse the downward arc the documented record establishes.

What remains is community-led representation. Documentation-first. Evidence-driven. Party-independent. Cross-issue. Public-record-building. Community-anchored. Persistent across electoral cycles in a way that no single party has been, and no single sympathetic government has been able to be.

This document is one part of that representation. It is one of approximately thirty primary documents produced by the ADSB campaign in its first four months of operation. It will be one of approximately sixty primary documents by the campaign's first year. Every document the campaign produces is in the public domain — free to share, free to print, free to post — because community-led representation is structurally incompatible with any form of access restriction. The work belongs to the community it represents. The community can use the work to make whatever case the community needs to make, in whatever forum, at whatever scale, on whatever timeline. The campaign exists to provide the analytic and documentary infrastructure. The community provides the political weight.

To the disabled Albertan reading this document

You are not alone. Approximately 730,000 Albertans share at least some part of your structural situation. Approximately 79,290 share the most acute part of it. The documented record this piece has constructed exists because your experience deserves to be on the record, not because the record itself will change your circumstances. The record is the foundation. What follows the record is up to all of us.

To the family member, the caregiver, the ally

You have been carrying weight that the structures documented in this piece should have been carrying. The structures were built to share the weight. The structures have, in varying degrees, abandoned that responsibility. The documented record establishes how, when, and under which governments the abandonment occurred. The record does not, by itself, restore the structures. It establishes the ground on which restoration can begin.

To the elected representative reading this document

Every elected representative in Alberta is on the public record on the actions documented in this piece. The voting records, the press releases, the Hansard transcripts, the cabinet memoranda are all primary sources. The community will be reading them. The community will be holding the record against your future actions. **The choice of which side of the documented record your name appears on is still available to you.** The Stelmach government's 2009 Samantha's Law amendment is on the positive side. The Kenney government's 2019 Bill 20 is on the negative side. The Prentice government's 2014 Michener reversal is on the positive side. The Smith government's 2025 Bill 12 Section 12.8 is on the negative side. The pattern is bipartisan. The choice is individual. The community has the documented record. The community will be using it.

To Peter Lougheed

Peter Lougheed died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that bears his name. He cannot read this document. He spent the last seventeen years of his life publicly arguing that the structures he built were being drawn down rather than added to. He named the structural mechanism ("selling the house to pay for the groceries"). He named the structural failure mode ("thinking like a manager rather than thinking like an owner"). He named the corrective principle ("*You have to manage the resource and that means to manage it with good public policy*"). He did not name the disability community specifically in any documented interview the campaign has located. He did not need to. The principle he kept restating applies to the disability community with the same force it applies to the Heritage Savings Trust Fund.

He was correct. He was correct for fourteen years he served as Premier. He was correct for twenty-seven years he watched his successors fail to maintain what he had built. He was correct for fourteen years after his death. He will remain correct for as long as the principle he stated applies to the wealth Alberta extracts from the ground and the wealth Alberta neglects from the people who live on it.

The disability community in Alberta does not need a new principle. The principle Lougheed stated in 2012 still applies. What the community needs is the structural representation that will hold successive governments to that principle, regardless of party, regardless of fiscal conditions, regardless of electoral cycles. **The campaign that published this document exists to begin constructing that representation.** What this document hopes the reader takes from it is the recognition that the construction is necessary, that the documented record has now been built, and that the work continues.

THE CLOSING SENTENCE

From greatness to betrayal. From assured income to conditional support. From appeal rights to internal review only. From senior parity to a \$200/month base-rate reduction. From dignity and independence to employment activity and opportunity to earn. From the most-positive disability-policy package in modern Alberta history to the most-comprehensive disability-policy restructure since 1979 — in forty-seven years. **The trajectory is real. The trajectory is documented. The trajectory is reversible. The community is the reversal mechanism. The campaign is one of the tools. The record is now built. The work continues.**

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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